

Information and Ideas

Theory + 56 Worked Questions • 7 Skills

1. Central Ideas and Details
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SECTION 1

Central Ideas and Details

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Central Ideas and Details

1–2 questions per module • tests two related but distinct skills: stating the single main idea of an entire text, and locating a specific detail the text actually states.

Main Idea vs. Detail Questions

- Main idea questions focus on the overall central point of the entire text — not just one paragraph or one example within it.
- Detail questions ask about specific information stated in the text — often signaled by phrases like “according to the text.”
- Supporting details back up the main idea. They are never the correct answer to a main idea question, even when they're true.
- A passage that opens with a common assumption and pivots with “however” almost always places its real main idea after the pivot.

Topic sentences are key. They usually appear at the start of paragraphs and often contain the answer.

How to Think: What the Correct Main-Idea Answer Looks Like

- No new information — the correct answer never adds a fact, cause, or judgment the passage didn't already state.
- No overly specific information — the correct answer is pitched at the level of the whole passage, not tied to one particular example, statistic, or sentence the passage used only to illustrate its point.
- Before reading the choices, compress the passage into your own one-sentence main idea. The correct choice should say the same thing you just said, in different words — not something narrower, and not something broader.
- If an answer choice could only be true because of one specific detail in paragraph two, it's a detail dressed up as a main idea — eliminate it.

Rule: Can you state the main point in one plain sentence before looking at the choices? The correct answer should match that sentence exactly in scope — same idea, no new information, and not narrowed down to a single supporting detail.

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns

Too narrow — true, but describes only one detail or one paragraph, not the whole text.

Too broad — extends the claim further than the text actually goes.

Too extreme — uses absolute language (“entirely,” “only,” “proves”) the text doesn't support.

Reversed or distorted — restates a detail from the text but changes its direction or meaning.

Half-right / half-wrong: contains correct elements but adds a false or unsupported claim.

Could be true, but unproven: plausible, but the passage does not fully support it.

Factually correct, not stated: true in the real world but not mentioned in the passage

WORKED QUESTIONS

Central Ideas and Details — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Hard

For decades, biologists assumed that the light produced by deep-sea anglerfish served only to lure prey close enough to strike. That light, however, is generated not by the fish itself but by colonies of bioluminescent bacteria housed in a specialized organ. Recent tissue studies show that the anglerfish supplies these bacteria with a steady flow of oxygen and nutrients they cannot obtain on their own in the surrounding deep water, while the bacteria, in exchange, provide a controllable light source the fish could not produce internally. The lure, in other words, is the visible product of a partnership neither organism could sustain alone.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.** Anglerfish are unable to produce light without the assistance of bacteria that live in the deep sea.
- B.** The anglerfish's glowing lure results from a mutually dependent relationship between the fish and light-producing bacteria, not from the fish alone.
- C.** Bioluminescent bacteria cannot survive in the deep sea without a host organism to supply them with nutrients.
- D.** Biologists have recently discovered that anglerfish use their lures exclusively to attract prey.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The text opens with the old assumption (light = a hunting tool) only to complicate it.
- The tissue studies reveal an exchange: the fish supplies oxygen/nutrients; the bacteria supply light.
- The final sentence names this directly as a partnership — that relationship, not the lure itself, is the point.

Tip

When a passage opens with what people “assumed” and pivots on “however,” the real main idea usually lives after the pivot, not before it.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it's true but only names half of the exchange (the fish's dependence), leaving out what the bacteria gain — exactly the detail the passage spends its second half establishing.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Anglerfish are unable to produce light without the assistance of bacteria that live in the deep sea.	Choice A is incorrect — Too narrow — states only the fish's side of the exchange and ignores the bacteria's dependence on the fish, which the text treats as equally important.
✓ B	The anglerfish's glowing lure results from a mutually dependent relationship between the fish and light-producing bacteria, not from the fish alone.	Choice B is the best answer. Matches the full scope of the passage: a two-way exchange, stated plainly in the final sentence (“a partnership neither organism could sustain alone”).
X C	Bioluminescent bacteria cannot survive in the deep sea without a host organism to supply them with nutrients.	Choice C is incorrect — Too narrow and slightly distorted — the passage never claims the bacteria categorically cannot survive elsewhere, only that this pairing supplies what each side lacks.
X D	Biologists have recently discovered that anglerfish use their lures exclusively to attract prey.	Choice D is incorrect — Directly contradicted — the whole point of the passage is that the old, prey-luring-only view is incomplete.

Question 2

Medium

The Silk Road is often summarized as a trade route along which silk, spices, and precious metals moved between East Asia and the Mediterranean. Caravans did carry these goods, but historians who trace the route's full record find a wider traffic: Buddhist and Islamic missionaries traveling with merchant convoys for safety, papermaking and printing techniques passing from workshop to workshop, and diseases such as plague spreading along the same corridors that carried textiles. The exchange of goods was, in this sense, only the most visible layer of a much larger movement of people, ideas, and pathogens.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.** The Silk Road was primarily responsible for spreading the plague across Asia and Europe.
- B.** Historians have concluded that goods such as silk and spices were rarely the most valuable items carried along the Silk Road.
- C.** The Silk Road carried far more than trade goods — it was also a corridor for religion, technology, and disease.
- D.** Merchants used religious missionaries as protection when transporting silk and other valuable goods.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The passage starts with the familiar trade-route summary, then widens it with “a wider traffic.”
- Three added categories follow: religion, technology, disease — all named as part of the same movement.
- The last sentence explicitly ranks goods as “only the most visible layer” — signaling the real point is the larger picture.

Tip

Count how many categories the passage lists after a phrase like “a wider traffic” — the correct main-idea answer usually needs to cover all of them, not just one.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: disease is one of three examples given, not the passage's focus, and the text never claims the Silk Road was the primary cause of the plague's spread.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The Silk Road was primarily responsible for spreading the plague across Asia and Europe.	Choice A is incorrect — Too narrow and overstated — disease is one of three supporting examples, and “primarily responsible” is a claim the passage never makes.
X B	Historians have concluded that goods such as silk and spices were rarely the most valuable items carried along the Silk Road.	Choice B is incorrect — Not supported — the passage never ranks goods against each other in value; it adds categories rather than downgrading trade goods.
✓ C	The Silk Road carried far more than trade goods — it was also a corridor for religion, technology, and disease.	Choice C is the best answer. Covers all three added categories (religion, technology, disease) and reflects the passage's shift from goods to the broader movement they traveled alongside.
X D	Merchants used religious missionaries as protection when transporting silk and other valuable goods.	Choice D is incorrect — Too narrow — describes one incidental detail (missionaries traveling with merchants) rather than the text's overall point about the range of what the route carried.

Question 3

Hard

Festinger and Carlsmith's classic account of cognitive dissonance holds that people who act against their own beliefs will often shift those beliefs to match the action — but only under specific conditions. In their original experiment, participants who were paid a token amount to tell a stranger that a boring task was enjoyable later reported believing the task actually was enjoyable. Participants paid a substantial sum for the same lie, however, showed no such shift: because their behavior was easily explained by the money, they felt no internal pressure to justify it by revising their attitude.

According to the text, why did the participants paid a small amount change their stated beliefs, while those paid a large amount did not?

- A.** The participants paid a small amount found the task more enjoyable than the participants paid a large amount did.
- B.** The participants paid a large amount were told to tell a different, more convincing lie than those paid a small amount.
- C.** The participants paid a small amount lacked an easy external justification for their behavior, so they resolved the tension by revising their belief instead.
- D.** The participants paid a large amount were more skilled at recognizing when they were being deceptive.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The text explains the large-payment group had an easy external excuse (“easily explained by the money”).
- Without that excuse, the small-payment group had no external reason to point to.
- The text states directly that this left them to resolve the tension “by revising their attitude” instead.

Tip

For “according to the text” detail questions, find the exact sentence that answers the question — the correct choice will restate it, not add outside reasoning.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it sounds like a restatement of the result, but the passage never compares how much either group actually enjoyed the task — only what they later reported believing, which is not the same thing.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The participants paid a small amount found the task more enjoyable than the participants paid a large amount did.	Choice A is incorrect — Confuses the reported belief with a real, measured difference in enjoyment; the passage describes a shift in stated belief, not an actual difference in experience.
X B	The participants paid a large amount were told to tell a different, more convincing lie than those paid a small amount.	Choice B is incorrect — Not stated — both groups told the same lie about the same task; only the payment amount differed.
✓ C	The participants paid a small amount lacked an easy external justification for their behavior, so they resolved the tension by revising their belief instead.	Choice C is the best answer. Directly restates the passage's causal explanation: no external justification → internal belief shift instead.
X D	The participants paid a large amount were more skilled at recognizing when they were being deceptive.	Choice D is incorrect — Not supported — the passage never discusses either group's skill at recognizing deception.

Question 4

Medium

Ukiyo-e prints of Edo-period Japan are often discussed as the achievement of individual master artists such as those who designed the images visitors most recognize today. Print historians point out, however, that a finished ukiyo-e print required a publisher who financed the project and judged the market, a carver who translated the artist's brushwork into wood blocks with his own technical judgment, and a printer whose choices about ink and pressure shaped the final color and texture. The single named "artist," in this account, functioned as one collaborator within a production process, not as the print's sole creator.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.** Ukiyo-e prints were created entirely by carvers and printers, with designers playing only a minor role.
- B.** Historians disagree about who deserves the most credit for the appearance of ukiyo-e prints.
- C.** A ukiyo-e print was the product of a collaborative process involving several specialized roles, not the work of a single master artist.
- D.** Publishers financed ukiyo-e prints primarily because they were confident the prints would sell well.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The passage first states the common view (single master artist), then complicates it with “however.”
- Three specific roles are named: publisher, carver, printer, each contributing distinct judgment.
- The final sentence draws the conclusion directly: the artist was “one collaborator,” not “the print's sole creator.”

Tip

When a passage names several contributing roles and then delivers a one-sentence verdict, that verdict — not any single role — is almost always the main idea.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it overcorrects. The passage repositions the designer as one collaborator among several, not as a minor figure whose role the carver and printer surpass.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Ukiyo-e prints were created entirely by carvers and printers, with designers playing only a minor role.	Choice A is incorrect — Too extreme — the passage repositions the artist as one contributor among several, not as a minor player outranked by the carver and printer.
X B	Historians disagree about who deserves the most credit for the appearance of ukiyo-e prints.	Choice B is incorrect — Not supported — no disagreement among historians is described; they are presented as in agreement about the collaborative process.
✓ C	A ukiyo-e print was the product of a collaborative process involving several specialized roles, not the work of a single master artist.	Choice C is the best answer. Matches the passage's structure exactly: common view → complication → collaborative-process conclusion.
X D	Publishers financed ukiyo-e prints primarily because they were confident the prints would sell well.	Choice D is incorrect — Too narrow — describes only the publisher's motivation, one detail among the three roles listed, not the passage's overall point.

Question 5

Hard

When a major European capital introduced a congestion charge for vehicles entering its center, city officials predicted the policy would reduce citywide traffic. Six months of data showed a 24 percent drop in vehicle volume within the charging zone itself, a result officials publicized widely. A separate analysis of traffic counts just outside the zone's boundary, however, found volumes there had risen by nearly 15 percent over the same period, suggesting that a substantial share of trips had been redirected rather than eliminated.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.** The congestion charge failed to reduce traffic anywhere in the city.
- B.** The congestion charge reduced traffic within the zone, but a fuller look at the surrounding data suggests much of that traffic simply moved rather than disappeared.
- C.** City officials deliberately misled the public about the effectiveness of the congestion charge.
- D.** Traffic volume just outside the charging zone rose by nearly 15 percent over six months.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The passage reports the officials' publicized success (24% drop) at face value first.
- It then adds a second data set — rising volume just outside the zone — introduced with “however.”
- The final clause interprets both findings together: traffic was “redirected rather than eliminated.”

Tip

When a passage gives one statistic that sounds like a clean success, check whether a second statistic complicates it — the main idea usually sits in how the two numbers relate, not in either one alone.

Trap

Choice D is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it is a true detail from the passage, but it is only one supporting number, not the conclusion the passage draws from comparing it to the first statistic.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The congestion charge failed to reduce traffic anywhere in the city.	Choice A is incorrect — Too extreme — the passage confirms traffic did fall within the zone; it complicates, but does not erase, that result.
✓ B	The congestion charge reduced traffic within the zone, but a fuller look at the surrounding data suggests much of that traffic simply moved rather than disappeared.	Choice B is the best answer. Captures both halves of the passage: the zone's real drop, and the redirection suggested by the surrounding data.
X C	City officials deliberately misled the public about the effectiveness of the congestion charge.	Choice C is incorrect — Unsupported — the passage describes officials publicizing an accurate result, not misleading anyone; the complication comes from a separate analysis.
X D	Traffic volume just outside the charging zone rose by nearly 15 percent over six months.	Choice D is incorrect — Too narrow — a single supporting statistic, not the passage's overall point about what that statistic implies.

Question 6

Medium

Octopuses change the color and texture of their skin to match their surroundings within a fraction of a second, a feat long assumed to depend on the animal directly seeing the background it was matching. Researchers studying octopus skin have since identified light-sensitive proteins embedded in the skin itself, distinct from the eyes, that respond to light striking the body directly. This finding suggests that at least part of an octopus's camouflage response may be coordinated by the skin's own photoreceptors rather than by visual information processed through the eyes and brain alone.

According to the text, what did researchers discover about how octopuses camouflage themselves?

- A.** Octopuses rely entirely on their eyes to detect background color before changing their skin.
- B.** Octopus skin contains light-sensitive proteins that may help coordinate camouflage independently of the eyes.
- C.** Octopuses cannot camouflage effectively unless both their eyes and their skin are exposed to light.
- D.** The proteins found in octopus skin are identical to the ones found in octopus eyes.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The text names the finding directly: “light-sensitive proteins embedded in the skin itself.”
- It specifies these are “distinct from the eyes” — a separate detection system.
- The closing sentence draws the implication: camouflage may be coordinated by skin, “rather than” eyes alone.

Tip

Watch for a phrase like “distinct from” right after a new finding is introduced — it's often the exact detail a wrong answer choice will try to erase or reverse.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it restates the old assumption named in the first sentence, which the rest of the passage exists specifically to complicate.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Octopuses rely entirely on their eyes to detect background color before changing their skin.	Choice A is incorrect — States the prior assumption the passage opens with, not the finding it goes on to describe.
✓ B	Octopus skin contains light-sensitive proteins that may help coordinate camouflage independently of the eyes.	Choice B is the best answer. Matches the passage's stated discovery precisely, including the key qualifier “distinct from the eyes.”
X C	Octopuses cannot camouflage effectively unless both their eyes and their skin are exposed to light.	Choice C is incorrect — Too extreme and unsupported — the passage never claims both systems must work together for camouflage to succeed.
X D	The proteins found in octopus skin are identical to the ones found in octopus eyes.	Choice D is incorrect — Not stated — the passage says the skin proteins are distinct from the eyes, not identical to anything found there.

Question 7

Medium

Many of the large public library systems built across American cities in the late nineteenth century trace their origins to gifts from wealthy industrialists. These donors, however, rarely simply paid to construct a building outright. A typical arrangement required the receiving city to commit its own tax revenue to operating costs and to provide the land, with the donor's gift covering only the construction of the building itself — a condition intended to ensure local governments would sustain the library after the donor's money was spent.

According to the text, what condition did industrialist donors typically attach to their gifts for library construction?

- A.** The city receiving the gift had to rename the library after the donor.
- B.** The donor retained ownership of the library building after construction was complete.
- C.** The city had to commit its own funds to operating costs and provide the land, while the gift covered only construction.
- D.** The donor required the library to be built in the city's wealthiest neighborhood.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The text names the typical arrangement directly, in one sentence.
- Two obligations are placed on the city: cover operating costs, and provide land.
- The donor's role is limited explicitly to “construction of the building itself.”

Tip

When a detail question asks about a “typical arrangement” or “condition,” look for the sentence that lists obligations — the correct answer usually needs to include all of them, not just one.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: donating money for a building sounds like it could come with ownership rights, but the passage never mentions ownership at all — only funding responsibilities.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The city receiving the gift had to rename the library after the donor.	Choice A is incorrect — Not mentioned anywhere in the text; naming rights are never discussed.
X B	The donor retained ownership of the library building after construction was complete.	Choice B is incorrect — Not supported — the passage describes funding obligations, not who legally owned the finished building.
✓ C	The city had to commit its own funds to operating costs and provide the land, while the gift covered only construction.	Choice C is the best answer. Restates the passage's stated condition in full: city funds operations and land, donor funds construction only.
X D	The donor required the library to be built in the city's wealthiest neighborhood.	Choice D is incorrect — Not stated — the passage never discusses where within a city the library had to be located.

Question 8

Hard

Public health messaging about antibiotic resistance often centers on a simple warning: the more antibiotics are used, the faster resistant bacteria evolve. Hospital surveillance data complicate this picture. Resistance rates rise fastest not simply where antibiotic use is highest overall, but specifically in intensive care units, where sustained, high-dose treatment of severely ill patients creates a uniquely strong selective pressure — killing off nearly all susceptible bacteria and leaving a narrow field in which only the hardest resistant strains can multiply and spread.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.** Antibiotic use in any hospital setting produces the same rate of bacterial resistance.
- B.** Hospital data show that resistance develops fastest under a particular kind of selective pressure, not simply wherever antibiotic use is highest.
- C.** Intensive care units should stop prescribing antibiotics in order to slow the development of resistant bacteria.
- D.** Susceptible bacteria are entirely eliminated once resistant strains begin to multiply in intensive care units.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The passage opens with the simple public-health message, then complicates it with hospital data.
- It specifies where resistance rises fastest: ICUs, not “antibiotic use” in general.
- It explains why: a particular kind of pressure (sustained, high-dose) creates a narrow surviving field.

Tip

When a passage narrows a general claim (“the more antibiotics, the more resistance”) down to a specific condition, the main idea is the narrowed, more precise version — not the general claim it starts with.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it sounds like the passage's opening claim, but the passage exists specifically to show that resistance does not rise uniformly with antibiotic use — it spikes under one specific condition.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Antibiotic use in any hospital setting produces the same rate of bacterial resistance.	Choice A is incorrect — Directly contradicted — the passage's whole point is that resistance rises fastest under one specific condition, not uniformly wherever antibiotics are used.
✓ B	Hospital data show that resistance develops fastest under a particular kind of selective pressure, not simply wherever antibiotic use is highest.	Choice B is the best answer. Captures the passage's actual claim: a specific selective pressure, not overall usage volume, best explains where resistance rises fastest.
X C	Intensive care units should stop prescribing antibiotics in order to slow the development of resistant bacteria.	Choice C is incorrect — Not supported — the passage makes no recommendation about prescribing policy; it only explains a pattern in surveillance data.
X D	Susceptible bacteria are entirely eliminated once resistant strains begin to multiply in intensive care units.	Choice D is incorrect — Too extreme — the passage says “nearly all,” not all, susceptible bacteria are killed off.

Quick Review — Central Ideas and Details

Skill	Frequen cy	Key Move	Main Trap
Central Ideas & Details	1-2/ module	State the main point in one sentence — no new info, not too specific.	Too narrow — a true detail, not the main idea.

SECTION 2

Command of Evidence: Textual

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Command of Evidence: Textual

1–2 questions per module • a claim is given, and you must identify which quotation from the text most directly proves it.

Theory

- You are not hunting for a quote that sounds smart — you are hunting for the line that directly proves the stated claim.
- Evidence must be both relevant (related to the topic) and sufficient (strong enough to prove the point on its own).
- Trap: a quotation that gives an example related to the claim but never actually states the claim itself.
- Trap: a quotation that is true and on-topic but supports only half of a two-part claim.
- If two choices both seem plausible, pick the one that is more specific and more directly tied to the exact wording of the claim.

How to Think: Predict, Then Match

- Read the claim first and cover the answer choices. Ask yourself: “What exact piece of evidence would I need to prove this?”
- Form that prediction in your own words before you look at a single choice — this stops well-written but off-target quotations from pulling you in.
- Match your prediction to the choices; the correct quotation usually contains the same specific noun, number, or relationship your prediction named.
- A quotation that merely relates to the topic in general terms, without proving the specific claim, is a trap — relevance is not the same as proof.
- Eliminate options that introduce misconceptions, give only examples, or are only partially relevant.

Rule: Read the claim first, form your own one-sentence prediction of what strong evidence would look like, then test each quotation against that prediction.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Command of Evidence — Textual — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Hard

Marine biologists studying octopuses in tide pools have proposed that octopuses use objects as deliberate tools rather than by chance encounter. One research team spent months recording octopus behavior on the seafloor, noting each time an octopus interacted with a coconut shell, rock, or other loose object.

Which quotation from the researchers' notes would most directly support the claim that octopuses use tools deliberately rather than by accident?

- A.** "An octopus was observed resting motionless beside two half coconut shells for several minutes before moving on."
- B.** "An octopus carried two coconut shell halves across open sand for several meters, then assembled them into a shelter and climbed inside."
- C.** "Coconut shells were more common on this stretch of seafloor than on any other section surveyed by the team."
- D.** "Several octopuses in the area displayed a similar mottled brown coloring during daylight hours."

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim needs a case where an object is carried, prepared, and used for a purpose — not just present nearby.
- Choice B shows all three: transport, assembly, and use as shelter — a sequence that rules out chance.
- Merely resting near an object, or objects being common, doesn't show intentional use.

Tip

For “deliberate” or “intentional” claims, look for a sequence of purposeful actions in the quotation, not just proximity or coincidence.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: an octopus near shells sounds relevant, but resting beside an object proves nothing about whether the octopus placed it there on purpose or was using it for anything.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	"An octopus was observed resting motionless beside two half coconut shells for several minutes before moving on."	Choice A is incorrect — Shows proximity, not use — resting beside an object doesn't establish that the octopus carried, prepared, or used it for a purpose.
✓ B	"An octopus carried two coconut shell halves across open sand for several meters, then assembled them into a shelter and climbed inside."	Choice B is the best answer. Shows transport, assembly, and functional use in sequence — the strongest possible evidence against pure accident.
X C	"Coconut shells were more common on this stretch of seafloor than on any other section surveyed by the team."	Choice C is incorrect — An environmental fact about shell frequency, not a behavioral observation — it says nothing about what any individual octopus did with a shell.
X D	"Several octopuses in the area displayed a similar mottled brown coloring during daylight hours."	Choice D is incorrect — Describes coloring, unrelated to tool use entirely.

Question 2

Hard

Engineering historians studying Roman aqueducts have argued that builders prioritized a gradual, tightly controlled downward slope over the speed with which a given aqueduct could be completed. Surviving construction records and surveys of aqueduct routes offer several possible pieces of evidence for this claim.

Which finding would most directly support the claim that Roman aqueduct builders prioritized a controlled slope over construction speed?

- A.** An aqueduct's route was extended by several additional miles, winding around a hillside rather than cutting straight through it, to keep the gradient consistent.
- B.** An aqueduct completed in a mountainous province took longer to build than one completed in flat terrain during the same decade.
- C.** Roman engineers used a leveling tool called a chorobates to measure small changes in elevation along a proposed route.
- D.** Several aqueducts remained in use for centuries after the fall of the Western Roman Empire.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim is a trade-off: slope control chosen over speed.
- Choice A shows both halves directly — a longer, slower route chosen specifically to protect the gradient.
- The other choices touch the topic (terrain, tools, durability) but don't show the trade-off itself.

Tip

When a claim describes builders choosing one priority over another, look for a quotation that names both sides of the trade-off, not just one.

Trap

Choice C is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: using a leveling tool sounds like proof of concern for slope, but it only shows engineers could measure elevation — not that they sacrificed speed to protect it.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	An aqueduct's route was extended by several additional miles, winding around a hillside rather than cutting straight through it, to keep the gradient consistent.	Choice A is the best answer. Directly names the trade-off: extra miles and a winding route (cost in speed) chosen specifically to preserve gradient (the priority).
✗ B	An aqueduct completed in a mountainous province took longer to build than one completed in flat terrain during the same decade.	Choice B is incorrect — A comparison of build times across different terrain types — doesn't show that slope control caused any given delay.
✗ C	Roman engineers used a leveling tool called a chorobates to measure small changes in elevation along a proposed route.	Choice C is incorrect — Shows engineers had the capability to measure slope, not that they sacrificed speed to protect it — a tool alone doesn't prove a trade-off was made.
✗ D	Several aqueducts remained in use for centuries after the fall of the Western Roman Empire.	Choice D is incorrect — About durability of the finished aqueducts, unrelated to the builders' construction-phase priorities.

Question 3

Medium

Ornithologists studying long-distance migratory songbirds have proposed that some species navigate in part by sensing the Earth's magnetic field, rather than relying only on star patterns or landmarks. Several experiments have been designed to isolate which cues a given species actually uses.

Which experimental result would most directly support the claim that a migratory songbird species uses magnetic-field sensing to navigate?

- A.** Birds housed in an indoor cage with an artificially rotated magnetic field consistently reoriented their attempted flight direction to match the field's new orientation.
- B.** Birds released at dawn and at dusk showed no measurable difference in their initial flight direction.
- C.** Birds of the species studied were found to migrate along nearly the same route in most years.
- D.** Birds exposed to a clear night sky before release showed stronger orientation than birds exposed to an overcast sky.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim is specifically about magnetic-field sensing, so the evidence must isolate that cue.
- Choice A manipulates only the magnetic field and shows the birds' direction changing in response.
- Choice D actually supports the opposite cue (stars), and the others don't test any cue at all.

Tip

When a claim names one specific cue, the strongest evidence is an experiment that manipulates only that cue and shows a matching change in behavior.

Trap

Choice D is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it involves birds' orientation ability, but the result actually points toward star-based navigation, not magnetic-field sensing — the opposite of what the claim needs.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Birds housed in an indoor cage with an artificially rotated magnetic field consistently reoriented their attempted flight direction to match the field's new orientation.	Choice A is the best answer. Isolates the magnetic field as the only variable changed, and shows behavior tracking it directly — precisely what a magnetic-sensing claim requires.
✗ B	Birds released at dawn and at dusk showed no measurable difference in their initial flight direction.	Choice B is incorrect — Compares time of day, not magnetic field exposure; says nothing about whether magnetism affects orientation.
✗ C	Birds of the species studied were found to migrate along nearly the same route in most years.	Choice C is incorrect — Shows route consistency, not which cue produces it — consistency alone doesn't identify the mechanism.
✗ D	Birds exposed to a clear night sky before release showed stronger orientation than birds exposed to an overcast sky.	Choice D is incorrect — Actually supports star-based navigation as a cue, working against, not for, the magnetic-field claim.

Question 4

Hard

Linguists studying early childhood language development have argued that children acquire grammar by inferring underlying rules from the speech they hear, rather than by memorizing and imitating adult sentences directly. Observational records of children's early speech provide several kinds of possible evidence.

Which observation would most directly support the claim that children infer grammatical rules rather than simply imitate the speech they hear?

- A.** A child was recorded saying "goed" instead of "went," applying the regular past-tense pattern to an irregular verb she would never have heard an adult use that way.
- B.** A child was recorded repeating a phrase, word for word, that a parent had used earlier in the same conversation.
- C.** Children in bilingual households were found to reach typical language milestones at roughly the same age as children in monolingual households.
- D.** A child's vocabulary grew most quickly during the months when her parents read aloud to her most frequently.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim needs an error no adult would model, which only a rule (not imitation) could produce.
- Choice A is exactly that: “goed” follows a regular pattern applied to an irregular verb — an error that couldn't come from copying.
- The other choices either show imitation directly or don't address grammar acquisition at all.

Tip

For claims about children inventing rules rather than copying, look for an error a child could not possibly have heard from an adult — that's the signature of rule-based inference.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it involves a child's speech, but repeating an adult's exact phrase is a textbook case of imitation — the opposite of what the claim is arguing for.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	A child was recorded saying "goed" instead of "went," applying the regular past-tense pattern to an irregular verb she would never have heard an adult use that way.	Choice A is the best answer. An error like “goed” could only arise from applying a learned rule to a new case, not from imitating anything an adult actually said.
✗ B	A child was recorded repeating a phrase, word for word, that a parent had used earlier in the same conversation.	Choice B is incorrect — Describes direct imitation — the very alternative explanation the claim is arguing against.
✗ C	Children in bilingual households were found to reach typical language milestones at roughly the same age as children in monolingual households.	Choice C is incorrect — About developmental timing across household types, unrelated to whether grammar comes from rules or imitation.
✗ D	A child's vocabulary grew most quickly during the months when her parents read aloud to her most frequently.	Choice D is incorrect — About vocabulary size and reading exposure, not about how grammatical structure is acquired.

Question 5

Medium

Marine ecologists studying "cleaning stations" on coral reefs, where small cleaner fish remove parasites from the bodies of larger fish, have argued that the arrangement benefits both the cleaner fish and the larger fish they service, rather than benefiting only the larger fish that receive free parasite removal.

Which finding would most directly support the claim that the cleaning arrangement benefits the cleaner fish as well as the larger fish?

- A.** Large fish that visited cleaning stations regularly were found to carry significantly fewer external parasites than large fish that did not.
- B.** Cleaner fish that had access to cleaning stations were found to gain measurably more body weight over a season than cleaner fish without such access.
- C.** Cleaning stations were located disproportionately in areas of the reef with strong currents and high visibility.
- D.** Large fish were observed opening their mouths and gill covers to allow cleaner fish to enter and feed.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim requires evidence of benefit to the cleaner fish specifically.
- Choice B shows a measurable gain (body weight) for the cleaner fish directly tied to access to the arrangement.
- The others describe the large fish's benefit or the setup, not a gain for the cleaner fish.

Tip

When a claim says “both sides benefit,” make sure the evidence you pick shows a gain for the side the question is actually asking about — not just for the more obvious beneficiary.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: it's true and relevant to cleaning stations, but it shows the benefit to the large fish, which was never in question — the claim needs evidence for the cleaner fish's side.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Large fish that visited cleaning stations regularly were found to carry significantly fewer external parasites than large fish that did not.	Choice A is incorrect — Shows the large fish's benefit, which the claim already assumes — doesn't address whether the cleaner fish also benefit.
✓ B	Cleaner fish that had access to cleaning stations were found to gain measurably more body weight over a season than cleaner fish without such access.	Choice B is the best answer. Shows a direct, measurable gain for the cleaner fish specifically — exactly the missing half of the claim.
X C	Cleaning stations were located disproportionately in areas of the reef with strong currents and high visibility.	Choice C is incorrect — Describes where cleaning stations are located, not who benefits from them.
X D	Large fish were observed opening their mouths and gill covers to allow cleaner fish to enter and feed.	Choice D is incorrect — Describes the mechanics of the interaction, not a measured benefit to either party.

Question 6

Hard

Economic historians studying medieval craft guilds have argued that guilds deliberately restricted the adoption of new production techniques in order to protect the value of existing members' skills, rather than simply lacking access to new methods. Surviving guild ordinances and court records provide several possible kinds of evidence for this claim.

Which piece of evidence would most directly support the claim that guilds deliberately restricted new techniques, rather than simply lacking access to them?

- A.** A city's textile guild fined a member for using a faster loom design that guild officials acknowledged was already known to them.
- B.** A guild's membership records show that the number of registered weavers declined gradually over several decades.
- C.** A neighboring city without a strong guild system produced textiles at a lower average cost than cities with active guilds.
- D.** Guild ordinances required members to complete a lengthy apprenticeship before practicing a craft independently.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim requires proof the guild knew about a technique and chose to block it anyway.
- Choice A shows both: officials “acknowledged” knowing the design, then fined its use — a deliberate choice, not ignorance.
- The other choices show declining membership, cost comparisons, or general training rules — none isolate a known technique being deliberately blocked.

Tip

To prove something was “deliberate” rather than accidental or due to lack of access, find a quotation showing the actor knew the alternative existed and acted against it anyway.

Trap

Choice D is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: strict training requirements sound like a form of restriction, but a lengthy apprenticeship is a general entry barrier, not evidence about blocking a specific known technique.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	A city's textile guild fined a member for using a faster loom design that guild officials acknowledged was already known to them.	Choice A is the best answer. Shows guild officials knew of the faster technique and punished its use anyway — direct evidence of deliberate restriction, not lack of access.
✗ B	A guild's membership records show that the number of registered weavers declined gradually over several decades.	Choice B is incorrect — A membership trend, with no stated cause — doesn't show a deliberate decision to block any technique.
✗ C	A neighboring city without a strong guild system produced textiles at a lower average cost than cities with active guilds.	Choice C is incorrect — A cost comparison between cities, which could result from many factors besides deliberate technique-blocking.
✗ D	Guild ordinances required members to complete a lengthy apprenticeship before practicing a craft independently.	Choice D is incorrect — Describes a general training requirement, not a case of a known technique being deliberately suppressed.

Question 7

Medium

Astronomers studying a distant variable star have proposed that its changes in brightness follow a regular, periodic pattern rather than occurring randomly. Several years of brightness measurements, taken at regular intervals, provide the primary evidence available to test this claim.

Which finding from the brightness measurements would most directly support the claim that the star's changes in brightness are periodic rather than random?

- A.** The star's average brightness over the full measurement period was slightly higher than astronomers had initially predicted.
- B.** The star's brightness peaked at intervals of very nearly 42 days throughout the entire measurement period.
- C.** The star is located in a region of the galaxy with an unusually high density of similar variable stars.
- D.** The star's brightness was measured using the same telescope and instruments throughout the study.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- “Periodic” specifically means occurring at regular, repeating intervals.
- Choice B gives exactly that: peaks recurring at “very nearly” the same interval throughout the study.
- The other choices describe overall brightness level, the star's neighborhood, or measurement consistency — none show a repeating pattern.

Tip

“Periodic” claims need evidence of a repeating interval — a single number (like a consistent number of days between peaks) is usually the strongest match.

Trap

Choice D is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: consistent instruments sound like they'd make the data more trustworthy, but consistent measurement conditions don't themselves show anything about whether the brightness pattern repeats.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The star's average brightness over the full measurement period was slightly higher than astronomers had initially predicted.	Choice A is incorrect — Describes overall brightness level, not the pattern or timing of its changes.
✓ B	The star's brightness peaked at intervals of very nearly 42 days throughout the entire measurement period.	Choice B is the best answer. States a consistent, repeating interval between brightness peaks — the direct definition of a periodic pattern.
X C	The star is located in a region of the galaxy with an unusually high density of similar variable stars.	Choice C is incorrect — Describes the star's surroundings, unrelated to whether its own brightness changes repeat on a schedule.
X D	The star's brightness was measured using the same telescope and instruments throughout the study.	Choice D is incorrect — Supports the reliability of the measurements, not the existence of a repeating pattern within them.

Question 8

Medium

The following lines are from an original poem in which a speaker describes returning to a childhood home many years later. Write a claim: the speaker's description conveys both a sense of loss and a flicker of unexpected comfort in the same moment.

Which quotation from the poem most effectively illustrates the claim that the speaker feels both loss and unexpected comfort at once?

- A.** "The porch has sagged, the paint has thinned, / the garden gone entirely to weed."
- B.** "I do not know this house at all, / and yet my hand still finds the latch."
- C.** "I turn instead and walk away, / back toward the car, the road, the dusk."
- D.** "They tore the old house down last spring / and built a newer, wider one."

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The claim needs a single moment holding two feelings at once — loss and comfort together.
- Choice B pairs unfamiliarity (“I do not know this house at all”) with an involuntary, comforting memory (“my hand still finds the latch”) in the same breath.
- The other choices show only loss, only retreat, or a fact with no stated feeling.

Tip

For a “both X and Y at once” claim, look for a single quotation that holds both feelings together — two separate lines that each show only one feeling won't satisfy the claim.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the sagging porch and overgrown garden are vivid signs of loss, which is half of the claim — but nothing in the line suggests any comfort alongside it.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	"The porch has sagged, the paint has thinned, / the garden gone entirely to weed."	Choice A is incorrect — Conveys only loss (decay, neglect) — no trace of comfort appears in the line.
✓ B	"I do not know this house at all, / and yet my hand still finds the latch."	Choice B is the best answer. Holds both feelings in one moment: unfamiliarity (loss of connection) alongside an instinctive, comforting gesture.
X C	"I turn instead and walk away, / back toward the car, the road, the dusk."	Choice C is incorrect — Shows retreat or avoidance, not a blend of loss and comfort.
X D	"They tore the old house down last spring / and built a newer, wider one."	Choice D is incorrect — States a plain fact about the house being replaced, without conveying any feeling at all.

Quick Review — Command of Evidence: Textual

Skill	Frequency	Key Move	Main Trap
Command of Evidence: Textual	1-2/ module	Predict strong evidence before reading the choices.	An example that never states the claim.

SECTION 3

Command of Evidence: Weaken

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Command of Evidence: Weaken

These questions ask: “Which choice, if true, would most weaken the argument?” Your job is to expose a gap in the author's reasoning — not to disprove the whole claim, only to make it less convincing.

How to Think: The Argument Structure

Every argument in a Weaken question has three parts:

- PREMISES — the facts stated in the passage. These are given as true. You never attack the premises themselves.
- ASSUMPTION (the gap) — the unstated belief that must be true for the premises to lead to the conclusion. This is what the correct answer targets.
- CONCLUSION — the claim the author draws from the premises, usually a causal claim (“X caused Y”) or a recommendation.

Rule: Evidence → [GAP / ASSUMPTION] → Conclusion. The correct weaken answer attacks the gap — by supplying a real alternative explanation, revealing a flawed comparison, or showing the effect happens even without the proposed cause. It never attacks a premise, and it never simply proposes “a different conclusion” instead of exposing the flaw in this one.

Four types of weakening answers:

Alternative explanation: introduce a different reason for the same observed result. The author assumed only one cause.

Counterexample: show a case where the evidence does not lead to the conclusion.

Missing evidence: point out a key piece of information the argument fails to account for.

Undermine an assumption: show that something the argument takes for granted is not actually true.

Key rules:

- A correct weaken answer makes the conclusion less likely — it does not have to make it impossible.

Trap: an answer that sounds negative but does not affect the argument's specific logic.

Trap: an answer that is relevant to the topic but does not address the reasoning gap.

Step-by-Step Approach

- Identify the conclusion — what is the author trying to prove?

Four types of weakening answers: (cont.)

- Find the reasoning gap — what does the author assume but never prove?
- For each answer, ask: "Does this directly attack the assumption or introduce an alternative explanation?"
- Eliminate answers that feel dramatic but do not affect the argument's logic.
- Choose the answer that makes the conclusion less convincing, even if it does not destroy it.

Wrong-Answer Traps Specific to Weaken

- Attacks a premise — disputes a fact the passage already states as true. Premises are never fair game; only the assumption is.
- A different conclusion — proposes an entirely separate takeaway rather than exposing the flaw in the stated reasoning. This does not weaken the argument; it ignores it.
- Actually strengthens — sounds critical but, read carefully, provides support for the argument instead.
- Off-topic — true and relevant-sounding, but never touches the specific causal link or comparison the argument depends on.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Command of Evidence — Weaken — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

A hospital introduced a new hand-hygiene protocol requiring staff to use an alcohol-based sanitizer before and after every patient contact. In the six months following the change, the hospital's rate of healthcare-associated infections fell by 31%. Hospital administrators concluded that the new sanitizer protocol was the cause of the decline in infections.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the administrators' conclusion?

- A.** Several nearby hospitals that did not adopt the protocol saw an even larger decline in infection rates over the same six months, coinciding with a region-wide improvement in ventilation standards.
- B.** Some staff members found the new sanitizer drying to their skin and requested a milder alternative.
- C.** The hospital's infection rate had been rising for several years before the protocol was introduced.
- D.** Alcohol-based sanitizers are generally considered more effective than soap-and-water handwashing.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the protocol was introduced; infections fell 31% over the following six months.
- Assumption (the gap): nothing else changed during that period that could explain the drop — the protocol is the only plausible cause.
- Choice A supplies a real alternative cause (region-wide ventilation improvements) and shows the decline happened even without the protocol, breaking the assumption directly.
- The premises themselves (that the protocol was introduced, that infections fell) are never disputed — only the causal link between them is attacked.

Tip

Before reading the choices, state the argument's assumption in one sentence: “Nothing besides X could explain Y.” The correct weaken answer almost always supplies that missing “something else.”

Trap

Choice C looks like it weakens the conclusion by adding context, but it actually only describes the situation before the protocol — it says nothing about what caused the change after the protocol was introduced, so it doesn't touch the assumption at all.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Several nearby hospitals that did not adopt the protocol saw an even larger decline in infection rates over the same six months, coinciding with a region-wide improvement in ventilation standards.	Choice A is the best answer. introduces a genuine alternative explanation (ventilation) and shows the effect occurred even without the protocol — this attacks the causal assumption directly.
✗ B	Some staff members found the new sanitizer drying to their skin and requested a milder alternative.	Choice B is incorrect — is true but irrelevant to whether the protocol caused the decline — it's an off-topic detail about comfort, not causation.
✗ C	The hospital's infection rate had been rising for several years before the protocol was introduced.	Choice C is incorrect — describes the period before the protocol, which doesn't address what caused the change afterward — it never touches the assumption.
✗ D	Alcohol-based sanitizers are generally considered more effective than soap-and-water handwashing.	Choice D is incorrect — would actually support the conclusion, not weaken it, since it makes the protocol's effectiveness more plausible, not less.

Question 2

Medium

A software company redesigned its onboarding tutorial to be shorter and more interactive. In the first quarter after the redesign, the percentage of new users who remained active after 30 days rose from 42% to 58%. The company's product team concluded that the redesigned tutorial was responsible for the improvement in 30-day retention.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the product team's conclusion?

- A.** The company simultaneously launched a major marketing campaign that specifically attracted users who were already familiar with similar products and thus more likely to stay active regardless of the tutorial.
- B.** User surveys showed that most people who completed the new tutorial rated it as “clear and helpful.”
- C.** The redesigned tutorial took engineers three months to build and test.
- D.** The company's main competitor also redesigned its own onboarding process around the same time.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the tutorial was redesigned; 30-day retention rose from 42% to 58% in the following quarter.
- Assumption: the tutorial redesign — and not some other simultaneous change — is what caused the retention increase.
- Choice A introduces a second simultaneous change (a marketing campaign attracting an already-more-likely-to-stay user base) that offers a competing explanation for the same result.
- This is a classic “simultaneous change” weaken pattern: whenever two things happen at once, the conclusion assumes the one being discussed is the true cause.

Tip

Watch for weaken answers that reveal a second change happening at the same time as the one in the argument — a true cause is hard to isolate when two things shift together.

Trap

Choice D might feel relevant because it involves a competitor's similar action, but a competitor's unrelated redesign has no bearing on why this company's own retention rate changed — it's off-topic.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	The company simultaneously launched a major marketing campaign that specifically attracted users who were already familiar with similar products and thus more likely to stay active regardless of the tutorial.	Choice A is the best answer. identifies a second simultaneous change that could fully explain the retention increase, undermining the assumption that the tutorial alone caused it.
✗ B	User surveys showed that most people who completed the new tutorial rated it as “clear and helpful.”	Choice B is incorrect — would actually support the conclusion by suggesting the tutorial was well received, not weaken it.
✗ C	The redesigned tutorial took engineers three months to build and test.	Choice C is incorrect — is a detail about development time with no bearing on whether the tutorial caused the retention increase.
✗ D	The company's main competitor also redesigned its own onboarding process around the same time.	Choice D is incorrect — describes an unrelated company's action that has no effect on this company's own retention data.

Question 3

Medium

In a small trial, participants who took a new supplement reported falling asleep an average of 12 minutes faster than participants who took a placebo. Because the difference held across all age groups tested, the researchers concluded that the supplement itself was responsible for the faster sleep onset.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the researchers' conclusion?

- A.** Participants who received the supplement could tell from its distinctive taste that they were not taking the placebo, and expected it to help them sleep faster.
- B.** The placebo group's average time to fall asleep was 26 minutes.
- C.** The trial included participants between the ages of 21 and 65.
- D.** The supplement is derived from a plant that has been used in traditional medicine for centuries.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the supplement group fell asleep 12 minutes faster on average; the effect held across all age groups.
- Assumption: the supplement's chemical properties — not participants' awareness or expectations — caused the faster sleep onset.
- Choice A introduces the placebo effect: because participants could identify which group they were in, their own expectation, not the supplement itself, may have caused the result.
- This is a two-step weaken: it doesn't deny the 12-minute difference (the premise) — it offers a different cause (expectation) for that same premise.

Tip

In trial-based arguments, always check whether the study was properly blinded. If participants could tell which group they were in, expectation becomes a live alternative explanation the argument has not ruled out.

Trap

Choice C states a true fact about the trial's design, but a wide age range actually supports the argument's claim of consistency across ages — it does not introduce any weakness.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Participants who received the supplement could tell from its distinctive taste that they were not taking the placebo, and expected it to help them sleep faster.	Choice A is the best answer. shows the trial may not have been effectively blinded, introducing participant expectation as an alternative explanation for the same 12-minute difference.
✗ B	The placebo group's average time to fall asleep was 26 minutes.	Choice B is incorrect — restates a data point already implied by the premises — a 12-minute difference — without weakening the causal claim.
✗ C	The trial included participants between the ages of 21 and 65.	Choice C is incorrect — actually reinforces the argument's claim that the effect held across age groups, rather than weakening it.
✗ D	The supplement is derived from a plant that has been used in traditional medicine for centuries.	Choice D is incorrect — is a historical detail about traditional use that has no bearing on whether the trial itself shows genuine causation.

Question 4

Medium

A city installed speed cameras on a stretch of highway known for frequent accidents. In the year after installation, the number of reported accidents on that stretch fell by 40%. City officials concluded that the speed cameras were effective at reducing accidents.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the officials' conclusion?

- A.** The same year the cameras were installed, the city also repaved the highway and added reflective lane markings that significantly improved visibility at night.
- B.** Drivers who received a speeding ticket from one of the cameras were required to attend a defensive-driving course.
- C.** The speed cameras were manufactured by a company that also produces traffic signal equipment.
- D.** The stretch of highway had been the site of several serious accidents in the five years before the cameras were installed.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: speed cameras were installed; accidents fell 40% over the following year.
- Assumption: no other safety-related change occurred at the same time that could explain the drop in accidents.
- Choice A introduces a real, simultaneous alternative cause — repaving and improved night visibility — that could independently explain fewer accidents.
- As with the tutorial and hand-hygiene examples, this is the “simultaneous change” weaken pattern applied to an infrastructure argument.

Tip

Ask: “What else changed around the same time?” If a weaken choice reveals a second plausible cause introduced at roughly the same moment, it almost always breaks a single-cause conclusion.

Trap

Choice D describes the situation before the cameras were installed, which might feel like useful context — but it says nothing about what happened after installation, so it cannot weaken a claim about the cameras' effect.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	The same year the cameras were installed, the city also repaved the highway and added reflective lane markings that significantly improved visibility at night.	Choice A is the best answer. reveals a second safety improvement made at the same time, offering a real competing explanation for the drop in accidents.
✗ B	Drivers who received a speeding ticket from one of the cameras were required to attend a defensive-driving course.	Choice B is incorrect — would actually support the conclusion by describing another way the cameras could reduce future accidents.
✗ C	The speed cameras were manufactured by a company that also produces traffic signal equipment.	Choice C is incorrect — is an irrelevant detail about the manufacturer with no bearing on the cameras' effectiveness.
✗ D	The stretch of highway had been the site of several serious accidents in the five years before the cameras were installed.	Choice D is incorrect — describes the pre-installation period only and does not address the cause of the post-installation decline.

Question 5

Hard

A company switched its entire customer service team to a four-day workweek, with no reduction in pay. Over the following six months, the team's average customer satisfaction score rose from 3.6 to 4.2 out of 5. Because no other changes were made to the team's staffing or responsibilities, company leadership concluded that the shorter workweek itself caused employees to provide better service.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the leadership's conclusion?

- A.** During the same six months, the company also replaced its outdated customer-service software with a faster system that cut average call-resolution time in half.
- B.** Employees reported feeling less stressed since the change to a four-day workweek.
- C.** A survey of the customer service team found that most employees preferred the four-day schedule to the previous five-day schedule.
- D.** Other companies in the same industry have also experimented with four-day workweeks in recent years.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the team moved to a four-day week with no pay cut; satisfaction scores rose from 3.6 to 4.2; leadership states no staffing or responsibility changes occurred.
- Assumption: because staffing and responsibilities didn't change, the only remaining explanation must be the shorter workweek itself.
- Choice A directly breaks this assumption by revealing a change leadership didn't account for — new software — that independently explains faster, better service.
- This shows why the premise “no other changes were made to staffing or responsibilities” is narrower than “no other changes were made at all” — the argument leaves a real gap despite sounding airtight.

Tip

When an argument insists “nothing else changed,” read that phrase precisely — it often rules out only one category of change (like staffing) while leaving other categories (like tools or software) completely open.

Trap

Because the passage explicitly says “no other changes were made to staffing or responsibilities,” it's tempting to think every possible alternative has already been ruled out — but the software change falls outside that specific, narrower claim.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	During the same six months, the company also replaced its outdated customer-service software with a faster system that cut average call-resolution time in half.	Choice A is the best answer. reveals a real, unaddressed alternative cause (new software) that falls outside the passage's narrower claim about staffing and responsibilities.
✗ B	Employees reported feeling less stressed since the change to a four-day workweek.	Choice B is incorrect — would tend to support the conclusion, since reduced stress plausibly links the shorter week to better service.
✗ C	A survey of the customer service team found that most employees preferred the four-day schedule to the previous five-day schedule.	Choice C is incorrect — reports employee opinion about the schedule, not evidence about what caused the rise in customer satisfaction.
✗ D	Other companies in the same industry have also experimented with four-day workweeks in recent years.	Choice D is incorrect — describes unrelated companies' experiments, which has no bearing on the cause of this specific team's improvement.

Question 6

Hard

An agricultural researcher found that fields treated with a new organic pesticide had 25% higher crop yields than untreated fields in the same region. Because the treated and untreated fields received identical amounts of water and fertilizer, the researcher concluded that the pesticide itself was responsible for the higher yields.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the researcher's conclusion?

- A.** Farmers chose which of their own fields to treat with the pesticide, and tended to select their most fertile, best-draining fields for the new treatment.
- B.** The pesticide is more expensive than conventional pesticides used in the region.
- C.** Crop yields varied significantly from year to year across the entire region, regardless of pesticide use.
- D.** The pesticide successfully reduced the population of a specific insect known to damage crops.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: treated fields had 25% higher yields than untreated fields; water and fertilizer were identical across both groups.
- Assumption: aside from water and fertilizer, the treated and untreated fields were otherwise comparable — the pesticide is the only meaningful difference between them.
- Choice A undermines this by showing the fields were not randomly assigned — farmers selected their best fields for treatment, meaning field quality (not the pesticide) may explain the yield difference.
- This is a selection-bias weaken: the comparison the argument relies on is not a fair, like-for-like comparison in the first place.

Tip

Whenever an argument compares two groups, check whether they were assigned randomly or self-selected. Self-selection is one of the most reliable ways to weaken a causal claim from a real-world comparison.

Trap

Choice C sounds like it introduces useful variability that could explain the difference, but it actually describes year-to-year regional variation, not a systematic difference between the treated and untreated fields being compared within the same study.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Farmers chose which of their own fields to treat with the pesticide, and tended to select their most fertile, best-draining fields for the new treatment.	Choice A is the best answer. reveals that fields weren't randomly assigned — the pre-existing quality of the chosen fields, not the pesticide, may explain the yield gap.
✗ B	The pesticide is more expensive than conventional pesticides used in the region.	Choice B is incorrect — is a cost detail irrelevant to whether the pesticide caused the yield difference.
✗ C	Crop yields varied significantly from year to year across the entire region, regardless of pesticide use.	Choice C is incorrect — describes broad regional year-to-year variation, which doesn't specifically explain the gap between the treated and untreated fields in this same comparison.
✗ D	The pesticide successfully reduced the population of a specific insect known to damage crops.	Choice D is incorrect — would actually support the conclusion by supplying a plausible mechanism for how the pesticide could raise yields.

Question 7

Hard

A city's public library system extended its hours at all branches, staying open two additional hours each weekday evening. In the following year, total library card sign-ups rose by 18% compared to the previous year. The library director argued in a report that the extended hours caused the increase in sign-ups, and used this claim to request funding to extend hours further.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the director's argument, without disputing that sign-ups did in fact rise by 18%?

- A.** The city's school district also began requiring library card registration as part of a new digital-textbook program launched the same year.
- B.** Total visits to library branches, not just sign-ups, also increased over the same period.
- C.** Some library patrons complained that the extended hours made it harder for staff to complete evening cleaning duties.
- D.** Card sign-ups had also increased, though more modestly, in each of the previous three years.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: hours were extended; sign-ups rose 18% the following year.
- Assumption: the extended hours are what caused people to sign up for cards, rather than some other new requirement or program.
- Choice A supplies a specific, powerful alternative explanation — a new school requirement — that would drive sign-ups regardless of library hours.
- Choice D might look tempting since it shows a prior trend, but a pattern of smaller prior increases doesn't rule out the extended hours as an additional contributing cause of this specific 18% jump — it only shows some baseline growth already existed, which is a weaker, less direct weaken than a full alternative explanation.

Tip

When two weaken choices both seem plausible, prefer the one that supplies a complete, specific alternative explanation for the exact effect over one that only shows a softer background trend.

Trap

Choice D can feel like the “safe, obvious” weaken answer because prior growth suggests sign-ups might have risen anyway — but it doesn't identify what actually caused this particular year's larger jump, so it weakens the argument only partially compared to Choice A's complete alternative explanation.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	The city's school district also began requiring library card registration as part of a new digital-textbook program launched the same year.	Choice A is the best answer. identifies a specific, powerful alternative cause (a new school requirement) that would independently explain the rise in sign-ups.
✗ B	Total visits to library branches, not just sign-ups, also increased over the same period.	Choice B is incorrect — would tend to support, not weaken, the idea that extended hours drew more library engagement overall.
✗ C	Some library patrons complained that the extended hours made it harder for staff to complete evening cleaning duties.	Choice C is incorrect — is an operational complaint with no bearing on what caused the rise in sign-ups.
✗ D	Card sign-ups had also increased, though more modestly, in each of the previous three years.	Choice D is incorrect — shows a softer prior trend but doesn't supply a specific alternative cause for this year's larger increase — a weaker, less complete weaken than Choice A.

Question 8

Hard

A retailer began sending personalized email recommendations to customers based on their past purchases. In the six months following the launch, customers who received the recommendations spent 22% more on average than customers who did not. The retailer's marketing team concluded that the personalized recommendations themselves caused customers to spend more.

Which choice, if true, would most weaken the marketing team's conclusion?

- A.** Customers were only enrolled to receive personalized recommendations if they had opted in through a loyalty program that also offered them exclusive early access to sales.
- B.** The recommendation emails were sent out every Tuesday morning.
- C.** The retailer's overall revenue for the year was higher than the previous year's revenue.
- D.** A competing retailer launched a similar personalized recommendation program shortly afterward.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: customers who received recommendations spent 22% more than those who didn't, over the same six months.
- Assumption: the two groups of customers (recipients vs. non-recipients) were otherwise comparable, so the recommendations themselves explain the spending gap.
- Choice A shows the comparison is flawed at its root: customers weren't randomly split into groups — only loyalty-program members, who already had a separate incentive (early sale access) to spend more, received the emails.
- The correct answer weakens the causal claim by exposing a selection problem in how the two groups were formed — it does not simply assert “the recommendations had no effect,” it explains specifically why the comparison is unfair.

Tip

The strongest weaken answers don't just contradict a conclusion in general terms — they expose the specific flaw in how the evidence was gathered or compared.

Trap

Choice C might seem like it strengthens the case for the recommendation program's success by showing overall growth, but it's actually irrelevant to whether the recommendations specifically caused the 22% spending gap between the two customer groups being compared.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Customers were only enrolled to receive personalized recommendations if they had opted in through a loyalty program that also offered them exclusive early access to sales.	Choice A is the best answer. exposes a selection-bias flaw: recipients were already loyalty-program members with a separate reason (early sale access) to spend more, undermining the direct causal link.
✗ B	The recommendation emails were sent out every Tuesday morning.	Choice B is incorrect — is an irrelevant scheduling detail with no bearing on the size of the spending gap.
✗ C	The retailer's overall revenue for the year was higher than the previous year's revenue.	Choice C is incorrect — describes company-wide revenue growth, which doesn't isolate or explain the specific 22% gap between the two customer groups.
✗ D	A competing retailer launched a similar personalized recommendation program shortly afterward.	Choice D is incorrect — describes a competitor's separate action, which has no bearing on why this retailer's own customers spent differently.

Quick Review — Command of Evidence: Weaken

Skill	Frequen cy	Key Move	Main Trap
Command of Evidence: Weaken	Varies	Attack the assumption/gap, never a premise.	Attacks a premise, or offers “a different conclusion.”

SECTION 4

Command of Evidence: Strengthen

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Command of Evidence: Strengthen

The mirror image of Weaken questions: “Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the argument?” Your job is to plug the argument's gap, not to prove it beyond all doubt.

How to Think: Confirm the Same Assumption

Strengthen questions use the identical PREMISES → [ASSUMPTION] → CONCLUSION structure as Weaken questions — only your target changes.

- Rule out an alternative explanation — eliminate a competing cause, making the author's explanation the only one left standing.
- Confirm the assumption directly — show the gap the argument relies on is, in fact, true.

Rule: “This only works if ____ is true.” The correct strengthen answer usually fills in that exact blank — watch for choices that support a different, related claim, or that merely restate the conclusion instead of supplying new confirming evidence.

Four types of strengthening answers:

Support the assumption: confirm the missing link the argument relies on.

Rule out an alternative explanation: eliminate other possible causes, making the author's cause more likely.

Provide direct evidence: give data or a fact that the reasoning actually leads to the conclusion.

Show the pattern is reliable: confirm that the example in the argument is consistent and not a fluke.

"This only works if ____ is true." The correct strengthen answer usually fills in that blank.

Trap: an answer that sounds positive but does not connect to the specific reasoning gap.

Trap: an answer about a different region or group — it must apply to the specific situation in the argument.

Step-by-Step Approach

Find the conclusion and the reasoning.

Identify the gap — what assumption does the author make but never prove?

Four types of strengthening answers: (cont.)

Complete the sentence: "This argument only works if ____ is true."

Find the answer choice that fills in that blank.

Eliminate answers that are positive but do not connect to the specific reasoning gap.

Worked Examples

Wrong-Answer Traps Specific to Strengthen

- Restates the conclusion — sounds supportive but adds no new evidence; it simply repeats what the argument already claims.
- Supports an unrelated benefit — true and positive, but about a different outcome than the one the argument is trying to prove.
- Weakens instead — introduces a competing explanation the argument would need to rule out, doing the opposite of the intended task.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Command of Evidence — Strengthen — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

A city replaced all of its streetlights with brighter LED fixtures along a stretch of road known for nighttime accidents. In the year following the change, nighttime accidents on that stretch fell by 35%. Traffic engineers concluded that the brighter lighting was responsible for the drop in accidents.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the engineers' conclusion?

- A.** During the same year, no other changes were made to the road's speed limits, signage, traffic volume, or surface condition, and weather patterns were consistent with previous years.
- B.** The new LED fixtures use significantly less electricity than the old streetlights.
- C.** Several residents wrote to the city praising the brighter, more modern appearance of the new lights.
- D.** The city plans to install similar LED fixtures on two more roads next year.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: brighter LED lighting was installed; nighttime accidents fell 35% over the following year.
- Assumption: no other change happened during that period that could explain the drop — the lighting is the true cause.
- Choice A directly confirms this assumption by ruling out every plausible alternative (speed limits, signage, traffic volume, road surface, weather), leaving lighting as the only remaining explanation.
- This is the mirror image of a weaken answer that would have introduced a simultaneous alternative cause — here, the strengthen answer eliminates that possibility instead.

Tip

A strengthen answer often works by ruling out competing explanations rather than praising the proposed cause directly — “nothing else changed” is one of the most powerful ways to confirm a causal assumption.

Trap

Choice B is a true, positive fact about the LED lights, but energy efficiency has nothing to do with whether the lights caused fewer accidents — it doesn't touch the assumption at all.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	During the same year, no other changes were made to the road's speed limits, signage, traffic volume, or surface condition, and weather patterns were consistent with previous years.	Choice A is the best answer. rules out every plausible alternative explanation, directly confirming the assumption that lighting alone caused the drop in accidents.
✗ B	The new LED fixtures use significantly less electricity than the old streetlights.	Choice B is incorrect — describes an unrelated benefit (energy use) that has no bearing on accident rates.
✗ C	Several residents wrote to the city praising the brighter, more modern appearance of the new lights.	Choice C is incorrect — reports resident opinion about appearance, not evidence about accident causation.
✗ D	The city plans to install similar LED fixtures on two more roads next year.	Choice D is incorrect — describes future plans, which provide no evidence about what caused the accident decline on this specific stretch.

Question 2

Medium

A manufacturing plant began giving employees a 10-minute stretching break every two hours. Over the following year, the plant's rate of repetitive-strain injuries fell by 28%. Plant management concluded that the stretching breaks were responsible for the decline in injuries.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen management's conclusion?

- A.** A nearly identical plant owned by the same company, which did not introduce stretching breaks, saw no meaningful change in its own injury rate over the same year.
- B.** Employees said they enjoyed having a scheduled break every two hours.
- C.** The stretching breaks were designed by a licensed physical therapist.
- D.** The plant's total production output remained steady throughout the year.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: stretching breaks were introduced; repetitive-strain injuries fell 28% over the following year.
- Assumption: the stretching breaks — not some broader industry trend or unrelated factor — caused the decline.
- Choice A supplies a comparison case: a similar plant without the breaks saw no change, which strongly suggests the breaks (the one real difference) are what caused the decline at the first plant.
- This is a control-group strengthen: showing that the effect appears only where the proposed cause is present is one of the most direct ways to confirm a causal assumption.

Tip

A comparison to a similar situation without the proposed cause is one of the strongest types of strengthen evidence — if the effect only shows up where the cause is present, the causal claim gets much more credible.

Trap

Choice C sounds relevant because it emphasizes the quality of the stretching program's design, but professional design alone doesn't provide evidence that the breaks actually caused fewer injuries — it's a credibility detail, not causal evidence.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	A nearly identical plant owned by the same company, which did not introduce stretching breaks, saw no meaningful change in its own injury rate over the same year.	Choice A is the best answer. provides a comparison case without the proposed cause, showing the effect appears only where the stretching breaks were introduced.
✗ B	Employees said they enjoyed having a scheduled break every two hours.	Choice B is incorrect — reports employee enjoyment, not evidence linking the breaks to fewer injuries.
✗ C	The stretching breaks were designed by a licensed physical therapist.	Choice C is incorrect — speaks to the program's design quality, not whether it actually reduced injuries.
✗ D	The plant's total production output remained steady throughout the year.	Choice D is incorrect — shows output was unaffected, which is irrelevant to whether the breaks caused fewer injuries.

Question 3

Medium

A university switched its introductory chemistry course from twice-weekly lectures to a “flipped classroom” model, in which students watched short videos at home and used class time for group problem-solving. Average exam scores in the course rose from 71% to 79% the following semester. The chemistry department concluded that the flipped classroom model caused the improvement in exam scores.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the department's conclusion?

- A.** The same instructor taught the course both semesters, using the identical textbook, exams, and grading rubric, and no other courses that semester saw a similar rise in scores.
- B.** Most students said in a survey that they preferred watching videos at home to attending traditional lectures.
- C.** The flipped classroom model has become increasingly popular at universities nationwide.
- D.** Group problem-solving sessions were scheduled for fifty minutes each class period.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the course switched formats; average exam scores rose from 71% to 79% the following semester.
- Assumption: the format change — not a different instructor, easier exams, or a broader trend across all courses — caused the score increase.
- Choice A rules out the most obvious confounding factors (instructor, materials, difficulty) and shows the increase was isolated to this specific course, strongly confirming the assumption.
- Notice this strengthen answer works exactly like Question 1's: by eliminating alternative explanations rather than praising the new method directly.

Tip

When a strengthen question involves a change in teaching or workplace method, check whether the correct answer holds every other variable constant — that's usually the strongest kind of confirming evidence.

Trap

Choice B reports a student preference for the new format, which sounds supportive, but liking a method is not the same as evidence that the method caused higher scores.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	The same instructor taught the course both semesters, using the identical textbook, exams, and grading rubric, and no other courses that semester saw a similar rise in scores.	Choice A is the best answer. holds every other variable constant and shows the score increase was isolated to this course, directly confirming the causal assumption.
✗ B	Most students said in a survey that they preferred watching videos at home to attending traditional lectures.	Choice B is incorrect — reports a preference, not evidence that the new format caused better performance.
✗ C	The flipped classroom model has become increasingly popular at universities nationwide.	Choice C is incorrect — describes a national trend, which has no bearing on what caused this specific course's score increase.
✗ D	Group problem-solving sessions were scheduled for fifty minutes each class period.	Choice D is incorrect — is a scheduling detail with no bearing on whether the new format caused higher scores.

Question 4

Medium

A city government launched a program offering small cash rebates to homeowners who installed water-efficient appliances. In the two years following the program's launch, the city's total residential water usage fell by 14%. City officials concluded that the rebate program was responsible for the decline in water usage.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the officials' conclusion?

- A.** Homes that participated in the rebate program reduced their individual water usage significantly more, on average, than homes in the same city that did not participate.
- B.** The rebate amounts offered by the program were larger than those offered by similar programs in other cities.
- C.** The city experienced slightly above-average rainfall during the two years after the program launched.
- D.** News coverage of the program was largely positive.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the rebate program launched; total residential water usage fell 14% over the following two years.
- Assumption: the program itself — not a citywide trend unrelated to participation — is what drove the decline.
- Choice A directly confirms this by comparing participating and non-participating homes within the same city, showing the effect concentrated specifically among participants.
- This is the same “compare with and without the cause” pattern as Question 2, applied at the household level instead of the plant level.

Tip

Whenever a strengthen answer choice offers a direct comparison between a group exposed to the proposed cause and a similar group that wasn't, treat it as a strong candidate — internal comparisons are hard to beat.

Trap

Choice C might seem like it explains lower water use, but reduced rainfall would be the version that suggests an alternative cause — above-average rainfall doesn't logically reduce residential usage in the same direct way, and either way it fails to isolate the rebate program's specific effect on participants.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Homes that participated in the rebate program reduced their individual water usage significantly more, on average, than homes in the same city that did not participate.	Choice A is the best answer. compares participating and non-participating homes within the same city, isolating the program's effect and confirming the causal assumption.
✗ B	The rebate amounts offered by the program were larger than those offered by similar programs in other cities.	Choice B is incorrect — compares this program's rebate size to other cities' programs, which says nothing about whether it caused the decline here.
✗ C	The city experienced slightly above-average rainfall during the two years after the program launched.	Choice C is incorrect — introduces a weather detail that does not isolate the rebate program's specific effect on participants.
✗ D	News coverage of the program was largely positive.	Choice D is incorrect — describes media tone, which provides no evidence about actual water-usage causation.

Question 5

Hard

A pharmaceutical company tested a new pain-relief medication against a placebo in a large clinical trial. Participants who took the medication reported a 45% greater reduction in pain compared to those who took the placebo. Because the trial was double-blind — meaning neither participants nor the researchers administering the treatment knew who received the medication versus the placebo — the company concluded that the medication itself, and not participant expectation, caused the greater pain reduction.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the company's conclusion?

- A.** Blood tests confirmed that participants who received the medication, but not those who received the placebo, showed a measurable reduction in the specific inflammatory markers the medication was designed to target.
- B.** The trial included participants from twelve different countries.
- C.** The medication has fewer reported side effects than a competing pain reliever already on the market.
- D.** News outlets reported on the trial's results shortly after they were published.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the medication group had 45% greater pain reduction than the placebo group; the trial was double-blind.
- Assumption: the medication's actual biological effect — not chance, dosage timing, or some other factor — caused the greater pain reduction.
- Choice A supplies a biological mechanism (reduced inflammatory markers matching the drug's designed target) that directly explains why the medication, specifically, caused less pain — this is stronger than simply reporting the pain scores again.
- This shows a more advanced strengthen pattern: confirming the assumption through an independent, mechanistic measurement (blood tests) rather than only ruling out alternative explanations.

Tip

The strongest strengthen answers in scientific contexts often supply independent, measurable evidence of the proposed mechanism — not just a repeated or restated version of the original outcome.

Trap

Choice C might feel like supporting evidence for the medication's overall value, but comparing side effects to a competitor says nothing about whether this medication caused the specific 45% greater pain reduction observed in the trial.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Blood tests confirmed that participants who received the medication, but not those who received the placebo, showed a measurable reduction in the specific inflammatory markers the medication was designed to target.	Choice A is the best answer. supplies independent biological evidence (inflammatory markers) directly tied to the medication's designed mechanism, confirming causation.
✗ B	The trial included participants from twelve different countries.	Choice B is incorrect — describes trial diversity, which has no direct bearing on whether the medication caused the pain reduction.
✗ C	The medication has fewer reported side effects than a competing pain reliever already on the market.	Choice C is incorrect — compares side effects to a competitor, which is irrelevant to whether this medication caused the observed pain reduction.
✗ D	News outlets reported on the trial's results shortly after they were published.	Choice D is incorrect — describes media attention, which provides no scientific evidence about causation.

Question 6

Hard

An airline introduced a new policy allowing passengers to select their seats for free at booking, rather than charging a seat-selection fee. In the following year, the airline's customer satisfaction scores rose significantly, and the airline's marketing department concluded that eliminating the seat-selection fee was the primary driver of the improvement.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the marketing department's conclusion?

- A.** A survey of passengers conducted after the policy change found that “seat selection” was the single most frequently cited reason for improved satisfaction, well ahead of any other factor mentioned.
- B.** The airline's on-time arrival rate also improved slightly during the same year.
- C.** Several competing airlines also offer free seat selection.
- D.** The airline's total passenger volume increased by 8% that year.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: the seat-selection fee was eliminated; customer satisfaction scores rose significantly the following year.
- Assumption: the fee elimination — specifically — is the primary factor behind the improvement, not some other simultaneous change like on-time performance.
- Choice A directly confirms this by showing passengers themselves identified seat selection, above all other factors, as the reason for their improved satisfaction — this rules out competing explanations from within the data itself.
- This is a strengthen answer sourced directly from the affected population's own stated reasoning, a particularly direct form of confirmation.

Tip

When available, a strengthen answer that reports the affected group's own stated reason for a change is one of the most direct ways to confirm which specific factor caused an outcome.

Trap

Choice B might seem supportive because it's another positive change at the airline, but an unrelated improvement (on-time arrivals) is actually a competing explanation for higher satisfaction, not confirmation that the fee elimination specifically was the cause.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	A survey of passengers conducted after the policy change found that “seat selection” was the single most frequently cited reason for improved satisfaction, well ahead of any other factor mentioned.	Choice A is the best answer. shows passengers themselves identified seat selection as the leading cause of their satisfaction, directly confirming the assumption.
✗ B	The airline's on-time arrival rate also improved slightly during the same year.	Choice B is incorrect — introduces a second, unrelated improvement that could itself explain higher satisfaction — this actually competes with, rather than confirms, the stated cause.
✗ C	Several competing airlines also offer free seat selection.	Choice C is incorrect — describes competitors' policies, which has no bearing on why this airline's own satisfaction scores rose.
✗ D	The airline's total passenger volume increased by 8% that year.	Choice D is incorrect — describes passenger volume, which is a different metric from satisfaction and doesn't confirm the cause of the satisfaction increase.

Question 7

Hard

A researcher studying employee productivity found that workers who were given the option to work from home two days per week completed 15% more tasks per month, on average, than workers required to be in the office five days per week. The researcher concluded that the flexibility to work from home caused the increase in completed tasks.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the researcher's conclusion?

- A.** Within the group given the work-from-home option, employees who actually chose to work from home on two or more days completed more tasks than those in the same group who chose to come into the office every day anyway.
- B.** The company's overall revenue increased during the period of the study.
- C.** Employees who worked from home reported enjoying more time with their families.
- D.** The office building where in-person employees worked was undergoing renovations during part of the study.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: workers with the work-from-home option completed 15% more tasks than workers required to be in-office full time.
- Assumption: it is the flexibility and time actually spent working from home — not some other difference between the two employee groups — that caused the productivity gap.
- Choice A strengthens this in an especially precise way: it shows a dose-response relationship within the flexible group itself — those who actually used the option performed better than those who had it but didn't use it — directly tying the outcome to the behavior in question, not just group membership.
- This is a more advanced strengthen pattern: a “dose-response” comparison, where more of the proposed cause lines up with more of the effect, even within a single group.

Tip

A “dose-response” pattern — where using more of the proposed cause tracks with a bigger effect, even within the same group — is one of the most convincing types of strengthen evidence, since it isolates the cause from group-level differences.

Trap

Choice D might seem like a red flag against the office group, but by itself it merely introduces a competing explanation for lower in-office productivity (renovation noise) — it doesn't confirm that flexibility specifically was the cause, and could actually be used to weaken rather than strengthen a clean causal story.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Within the group given the work-from-home option, employees who actually chose to work from home on two or more days completed more tasks than those in the same group who chose to come into the office every day anyway.	Choice A is the best answer. shows a dose-response relationship within the flexible group itself, directly tying more time working from home to more completed tasks.
✗ B	The company's overall revenue increased during the period of the study.	Choice B is incorrect — describes overall company revenue, which is too broad a measure to confirm this specific productivity claim.
✗ C	Employees who worked from home reported enjoying more time with their families.	Choice C is incorrect — reports personal satisfaction, not evidence about task completion.
✗ D	The office building where in-person employees worked was undergoing renovations during part of the study.	Choice D is incorrect — introduces a competing explanation (renovation disruption) for lower in-office productivity, which muddies rather than confirms the causal claim.

Question 8

Hard

A conservation group reintroduced beavers to a river system after a decades-long absence. Over the following five years, the group observed a significant increase in local fish populations and concluded that the beavers' dam-building activity, which creates deep, slow-moving pools, was responsible for the rise in fish numbers.

Which choice, if true, would most strengthen the conservation group's conclusion?

- A.** Fish populations increased specifically in the stretches of river where beaver dams were built, while stretches of the same river without dams showed no significant change in fish numbers over the same five years.
- B.** Beavers primarily feed on tree bark and aquatic plants rather than on fish.
- C.** The reintroduced beaver population itself grew steadily over the five years.
- D.** Local anglers reported that beavers were initially unpopular among some river-users.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: beavers were reintroduced; fish populations increased significantly over the following five years.
- Assumption: the beaver dams' effect on the river habitat — not some other regional or seasonal factor — caused the rise in fish numbers.
- Choice A confirms this with a precise internal comparison: fish increased specifically where dams were built, and not in dam-free stretches of the very same river, isolating the dams as the responsible factor.
- This mirrors the pattern from Questions 2 and 4: comparing conditions with and without the proposed cause, but this time within the same river system for maximum control over outside variables.

Tip

The most convincing strengthen evidence often narrows the comparison as much as possible — comparing dammed and non-dammed stretches of the exact same river controls for weather, season, and region far better than a broader before-and-after comparison alone.

Trap

Choice B is true and might seem reassuring (beavers aren't eating the fish), but it doesn't provide any positive evidence that the dams specifically caused the fish population to rise — it only rules out one unlikely alternative explanation the passage never raised.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Fish populations increased specifically in the stretches of river where beaver dams were built, while stretches of the same river without dams showed no significant change in fish numbers over the same five years.	Choice A is the best answer. isolates the dams as the cause by comparing dammed and non-dammed stretches of the same river, directly confirming the assumption.
✗ B	Beavers primarily feed on tree bark and aquatic plants rather than on fish.	Choice B is incorrect — rules out an explanation the passage never suggested (beavers eating fish) rather than confirming the actual proposed cause.
✗ C	The reintroduced beaver population itself grew steadily over the five years.	Choice C is incorrect — describes the beaver population's growth, which doesn't directly confirm the mechanism by which fish populations rose.
✗ D	Local anglers reported that beavers were initially unpopular among some river-users.	Choice D is incorrect — reports human opinion about beavers, which has no bearing on the ecological cause of the fish increase.

Quick Review — Command of Evidence: Strengthen

Skill	Frequen cy	Key Move	Main Trap
Command of Evidence: Strengthen	Varies	Confirm the same assumption Weaken would attack.	Restates the conclusion instead of adding evidence.

SECTION 5

Command of Evidence: Quantitative

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Command of Evidence: Quantitative

1–2 questions per module • a claim is paired with a table or graph, and you must identify the data point (or pattern) that most directly proves — or disproves — it. On the real exam this sometimes means reading a graph alone, and sometimes means checking a written claim against a graph.

Theory

- Read every axis, label, and legend before looking at the answer choices — state the trend in one plain sentence first.
- Match the data to the specific claim in the question, not to what the data means in general.
- Watch for claims with two parts (“rises, then levels off,” “X leads Y, and the gap widens”) — the correct choice must address both parts, not just one.
- Do not overinterpret. The exam only asks about what the table or graph literally shows.
- Sometimes the whole point is that the data contradicts the author's claim — stay alert to this.
- Before looking at the answer choices, state what the graph is showing in the simplest possible terms.

How to Think: Combined Text-and-Data Questions

Trap answers:

Off-topic data point: a real number from the graph that has nothing to do with the claim.

Partial support: related but not the strongest or most direct match.

Comparison without context: a difference that does not directly support the specific claim in the passage.

Step-by-Step Approach

Read the passage claim — identify exactly what the author is arguing.

Read the chart title, axis labels, and units before looking at any numbers.

In plain English, describe what the chart is showing overall.

For each answer choice, ask: "Does this specific data point directly prove the claim?"

Choose the most direct and specific match.

How to Think: Combined Text-and-Data Questions (cont.)

Trap: a technically true number pulled from the table or graph that doesn't actually address the specific claim in the question — always re-check the choice against the exact claim, not just against the data.

WORKED QUESTIONS

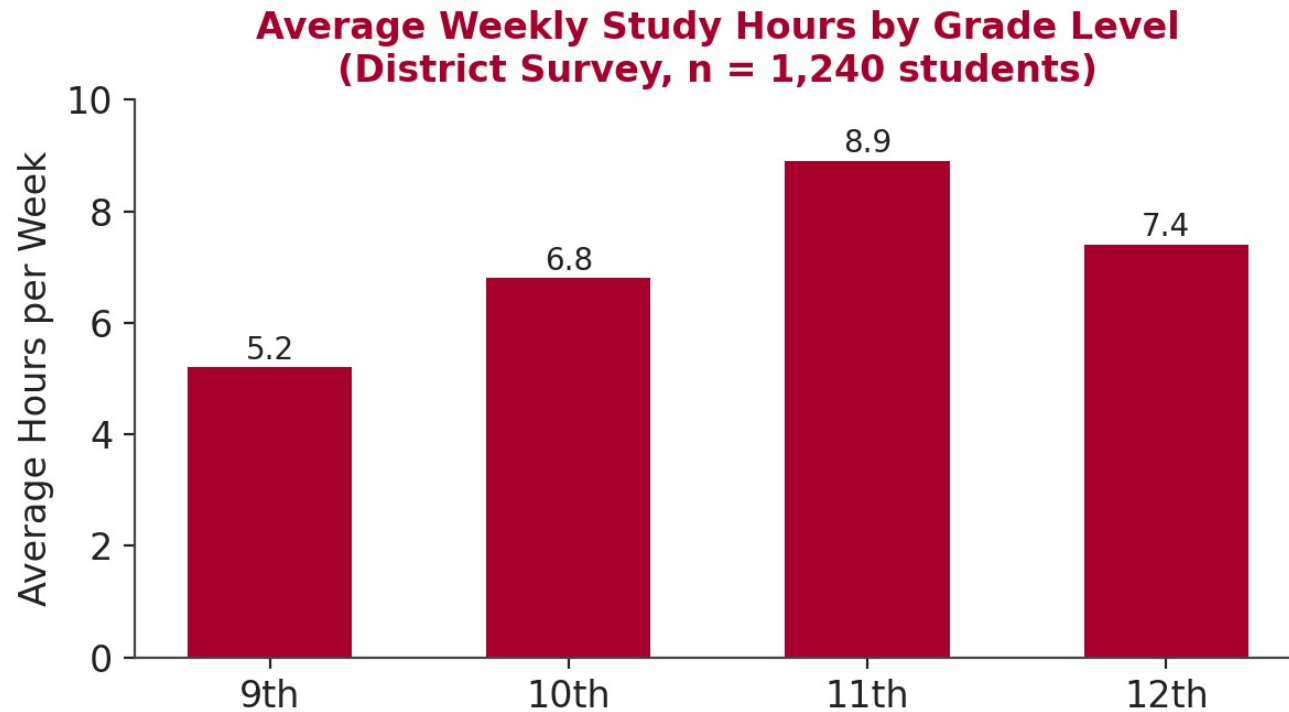
Command of Evidence — Quantitative — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

A district researcher surveyed 1,240 students about their average weekly study hours, broken down by grade level. The results are shown in the bar graph.



Which choice most accurately describes the data shown in the graph?

- A.** Average weekly study hours increased steadily from 9th grade through 12th grade.
- B.** 10th graders reported studying more hours per week, on average, than 12th graders.
- C.** 11th graders reported the highest average weekly study hours of the four grade levels shown.
- D.** 9th graders and 12th graders reported roughly the same average weekly study hours.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Reading the bars directly: 9th $\approx$ 5.2 hours, 10th $\approx$ 6.8 hours, 11th $\approx$ 8.9 hours, 12th $\approx$ 7.4 hours.
- 11th grade has the tallest bar at 8.9 hours, the highest of all four grade levels.
- The pattern rises from 9th to 11th grade and then falls at 12th grade — it is not a steady increase across all four levels.

Tip

Before looking at the answer choices, state the shape of the data yourself in one sentence: here, “it rises, peaks at 11th grade, then drops.” Match that shape to the choices.

Trap

Choice A is tempting because the first three bars really do increase, but the pattern breaks at 12th grade, where the value drops — “steadily” requires the whole trend to hold, not just most of it.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

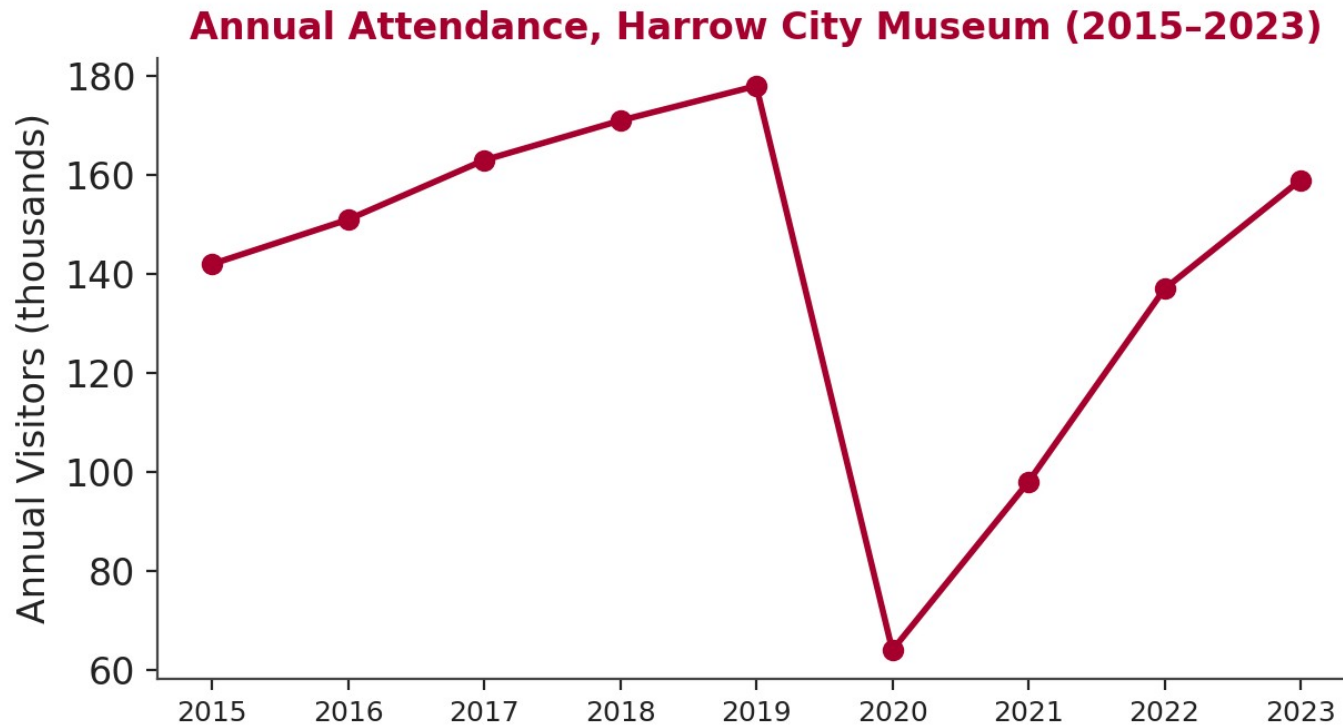
Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Average weekly study hours increased steadily from 9th grade through 12th grade.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the drop from 11th grade (8.9) to 12th grade (7.4) — the increase is not steady across all four levels.
X B	10th graders reported studying more hours per week, on average, than 12th graders.	Choice B is incorrect — is contradicted directly by the graph: 10th grade (6.8) is lower than 12th grade (7.4), not higher.
✓ C	11th graders reported the highest average weekly study hours of the four grade levels shown.	Choice C is the best answer. matches the graph exactly — 11th grade's bar (8.9 hours) is the tallest of the four.
X D	9th graders and 12th graders reported roughly the same average weekly study hours.	Choice D is incorrect — is contradicted by the graph — 9th grade (5.2) and 12th grade (7.4) differ by over two hours, not “roughly the same.”

Question 2

Easy

A city museum tracked its total annual visitor count from 2015 through 2023, shown in the line graph.



Which choice most accurately describes the trend shown in the graph?

- A.** Attendance rose every single year from 2015 to 2023 without exception.
- B.** Attendance rose from 2015 to 2019, dropped sharply in 2020, and then began rising again through 2023.
- C.** Attendance in 2023 was lower than attendance in 2015.
- D.** Attendance was highest in 2020.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- Reading the line: attendance rises steadily from 2015 (142k) to 2019 (178k), drops sharply to 2020 (64k), then climbs again through 2021, 2022, and 2023 (159k).
- This matches a rise, a sharp interruption, then a recovery — not a single uninterrupted trend in either direction.
- 2023's value (159k) is higher than 2015's value (142k), ruling out a simple decline.

Tip

When a line graph has a sharp dip in the middle, describe the trend in three parts — before, during, and after the dip — rather than trying to summarize the whole graph in one direction.

Trap

Choice D seizes on the idea that 2020 stands out as unusual, but the graph shows 2020 as the lowest point, not the highest — a common error is confusing “most notable” with “highest.”

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

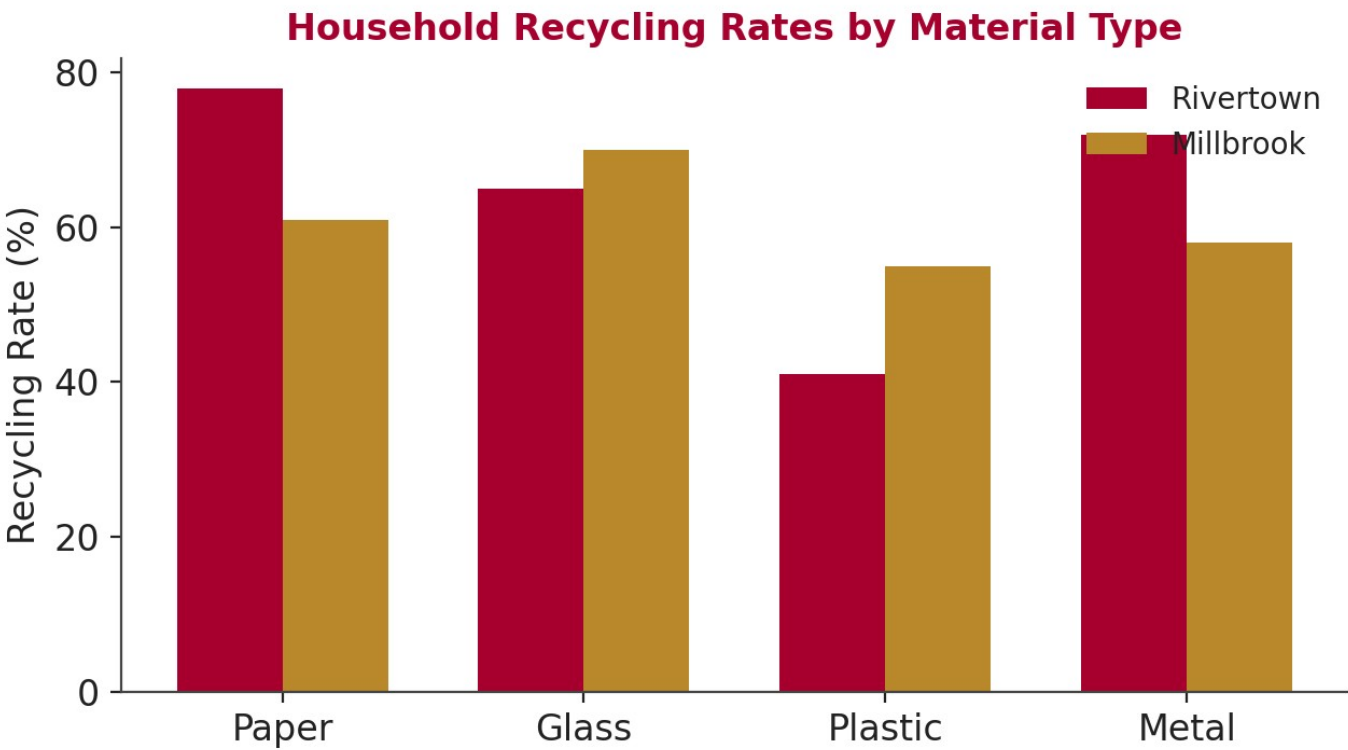
Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Attendance rose every single year from 2015 to 2023 without exception.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the sharp drop between 2019 and 2020 visible on the graph.
✓ B	Attendance rose from 2015 to 2019, dropped sharply in 2020, and then began rising again through 2023.	Choice B is the best answer. accurately describes all three phases shown: the rise through 2019, the 2020 drop, and the recovery through 2023.
X C	Attendance in 2023 was lower than attendance in 2015.	Choice C is incorrect — is contradicted by the graph — 2023 (159k) is higher than 2015 (142k).
X D	Attendance was highest in 2020.	Choice D is incorrect — is the opposite of what the graph shows — 2020 is the lowest point on the line, not the highest.

Question 3

Medium

Two neighboring towns, Rivertown and Millbrook, measured their household recycling rates by material type, shown in the grouped bar graph.



Which choice is most strongly supported by the data shown in the graph?

- A. Rivertown had a higher recycling rate than Millbrook for every material type shown.
- B. Rivertown's plastic recycling rate exceeded Millbrook's plastic recycling rate.
- C. Both towns recycled paper at a higher rate than they recycled plastic.
- D. Millbrook's glass recycling rate was more than double Rivertown's glass recycling rate.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Reading each pair of bars: Paper — Rivertown 78%, Millbrook 61%. Glass — Rivertown 65%, Millbrook 70%. Plastic — Rivertown 41%, Millbrook 55%. Metal — Rivertown 72%, Millbrook 58%.
- For both towns, the paper bar is taller than the plastic bar ($78\% > 41\%$ for Rivertown; $61\% > 55\%$ for Millbrook), confirming Choice C.
- Choice A fails on glass (Millbrook's 70% beats Rivertown's 65%), so “every material type” is too strong.

Tip

When a choice uses “every” or “each,” check every single relevant data point before accepting it — one exception anywhere in the graph is enough to eliminate it.

Trap

Choice A is true for three of the four materials (paper, plastic, metal), which makes it easy to accept without checking glass — always verify absolute claims against the full data set, not just the first few points you notice.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

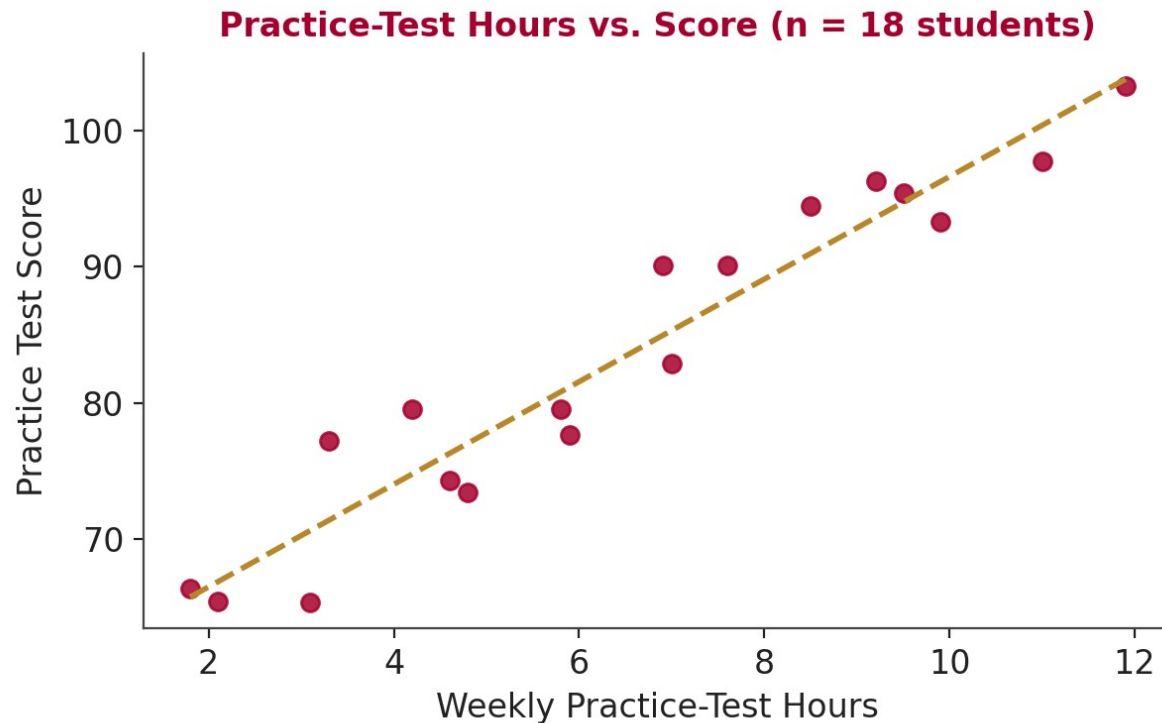
Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Rivertown had a higher recycling rate than Millbrook for every material type shown.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the glass category, where Millbrook (70%) actually exceeds Rivertown (65%).
X B	Rivertown's plastic recycling rate exceeded Millbrook's plastic recycling rate.	Choice B is incorrect — is contradicted directly — Millbrook's plastic rate (55%) exceeds Rivertown's (41%), the reverse of what this choice claims.
✓ C	Both towns recycled paper at a higher rate than they recycled plastic.	Choice C is the best answer. holds for both towns: paper (78%, 61%) is higher than plastic (41%, 55%) in each town.
X D	Millbrook's glass recycling rate was more than double Rivertown's glass recycling rate.	Choice D is incorrect — is contradicted by the actual values — Millbrook's glass rate (70%) is not more than double Rivertown's (65%); the two are close, not double.

Question 4

Medium

A tutor tracked 18 students' weekly practice-test hours against their most recent practice test score, shown in the scatter plot. A trend line (dashed) is included.



Which choice best describes the relationship shown in the scatter plot?

- A.** There is no meaningful relationship between practice-test hours and test scores.
- B.** As weekly practice-test hours increase, test scores tend to increase as well, though not perfectly for every student.
- C.** Every student who studied more hours per week scored higher than every student who studied fewer hours.
- D.** Test scores decrease as weekly practice-test hours increase.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The dashed trend line slopes upward from left to right, indicating a positive relationship between hours and score.
- The dots do not fall in a perfectly straight line — several points sit above or below the trend line, showing the relationship holds “on average” rather than for every single student.
- This is a moderate positive correlation: real, visible, but not perfect — the language of the correct choice must reflect that nuance.

Tip

A scatter plot's trend line tells you the general direction of a relationship; the scatter of individual points around that line tells you how consistent or “noisy” the relationship is. A correct description usually needs to acknowledge both.

Trap

Choice C overstates a real positive trend into an absolute, guaranteed rule — but a scatter plot with any points that don't perfectly follow the trend line can never support an “every single student” claim.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

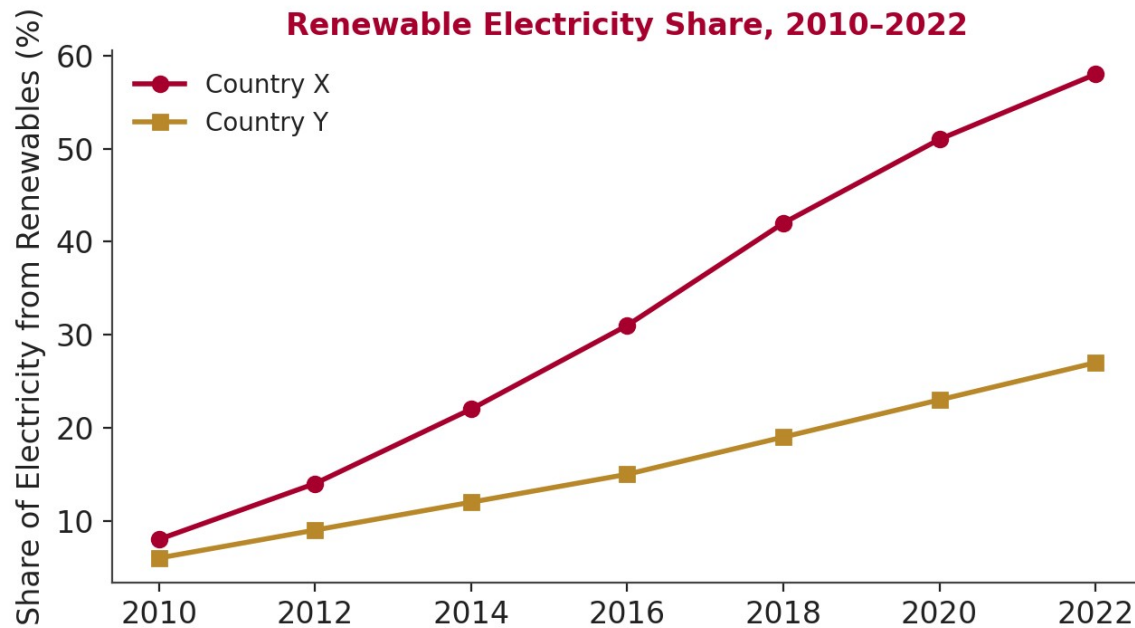
Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	There is no meaningful relationship between practice-test hours and test scores.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the clearly upward-sloping trend line, which shows a real relationship exists.
✓ B	As weekly practice-test hours increase, test scores tend to increase as well, though not perfectly for every student.	Choice B is the best answer. accurately captures both the upward trend and the natural scatter of individual points around it.
X C	Every student who studied more hours per week scored higher than every student who studied fewer hours.	Choice C is incorrect — overstates the trend into a guaranteed rule, which the scattered (non-perfectly-aligned) points do not support.
X D	Test scores decrease as weekly practice-test hours increase.	Choice D is incorrect — describes the opposite direction of the relationship actually shown by the upward-sloping trend line.

Question 5

Medium

An energy policy analyst wrote: “Country X’s renewable energy transition has not only outpaced Country Y’s, but the gap between the two countries has continued to widen every single year since 2010.” The line graph shows each country’s share of electricity generated from renewable sources from 2010 to 2022.



Does the graph support the analyst's claim?

- A.** Yes, because Country X's share was higher than Country Y's share in every year shown, and the gap between the two lines grew larger at each measured point.
- B.** Yes, because both countries increased their renewable energy share every year shown.
- C.** No, because Country Y's share was higher than Country X's share for most of the period shown.
- D.** No, because the gap between the two countries narrowed after 2018.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Country X rises from 8% (2010) to 58% (2022); Country Y rises from 6% (2010) to 27% (2022) — Country X is higher at every single measured point.
- The gap at each point: 2010 (2 pts), 2012 (5 pts), 2014 (10 pts), 2016 (16 pts), 2018 (23 pts), 2020 (28 pts), 2022 (31 pts) — the gap grows larger every time, confirming the second half of the claim too.
- Because the claim has two parts (X ahead of Y, and the gap widening), the correct answer must verify both parts against the graph, not just one.

Tip

When a claim makes two separate assertions (here: “outpaced” and “gap widening every year”), check each one against the data separately — a choice can only be fully correct if it holds up on both counts.

Trap

Choice B is a true statement on its own (both lines do rise every year), but it doesn't actually verify the analyst's specific claim about Country X leading and the gap widening — it answers a different, easier question than the one being asked.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

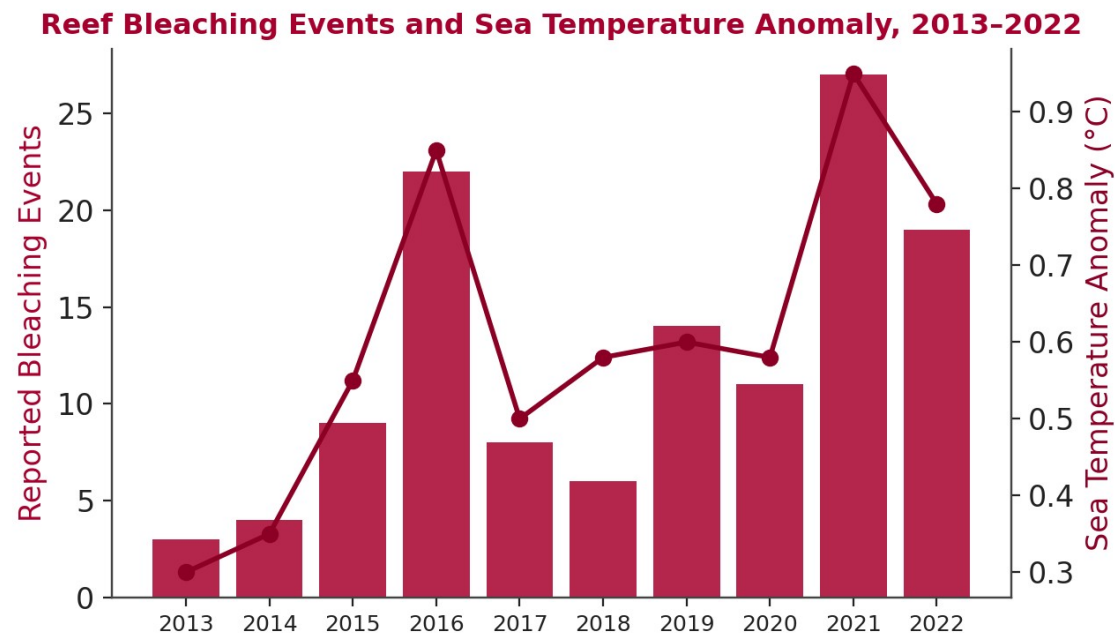
Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Yes, because Country X's share was higher than Country Y's share in every year shown, and the gap between the two lines grew larger at each measured point.	Choice A is the best answer. verifies both parts of the claim: Country X stays ahead at every point, and the numerical gap between the two lines increases at each interval.
✗ B	Yes, because both countries increased their renewable energy share every year shown.	Choice B is incorrect — confirms a true but different fact (both countries grew) without addressing the specific claim about the gap between them.
✗ C	No, because Country Y's share was higher than Country X's share for most of the period shown.	Choice C is incorrect — is contradicted by the graph — Country X's line sits above Country Y's line at every single point shown.
✗ D	No, because the gap between the two countries narrowed after 2018.	Choice D is incorrect — is contradicted by the graph — the gap continues to widen through the final interval (28 to 31 points), not narrow.

Question 6

Hard

A marine biologist wrote: “Every year sea temperature anomaly rises compared to the year before, the number of reported coral bleaching events also rises compared to the year before, with no exceptions.” The chart shows reported bleaching events (bars, left axis) and sea temperature anomaly (line, right axis) from 2013 to 2022.



Does the chart support the marine biologist's claim?

- A.** Yes, the two measures move in the same direction relative to the prior year in every single year shown.
- B.** No, because 2018 shows a year where the temperature anomaly rose from the year before, but the number of bleaching events fell from the year before.
- C.** No, because bleaching events and temperature anomaly were both at their highest in 2021, which the claim does not account for.
- D.** No, because temperature anomaly and bleaching events moved in opposite directions in most years shown, not just a few.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Checking year-over-year direction: 2017→2018, temperature anomaly rises from 0.5 to 0.58 (up), but bleaching events fall from 8 to 6 (down) — one clear exception to the claim.
- This single exception is enough to disprove an “every year, with no exceptions” claim, even if most other years do move together.
- The biologist's claim is absolute (“every year... with no exceptions”), so the correct answer only needs to locate one specific counterexample, not a general pattern of disagreement.

Tip

An absolute claim (“every,” “always,” “with no exceptions”) can be disproven by finding just one exception — you don't need to show the whole pattern is wrong, only that it isn't perfectly consistent.

Trap

Choice D overreaches by claiming the two measures moved oppositely “in most years,” when in fact most years do move together — only 2018 breaks the pattern, so this choice describes a much bigger disagreement with the data than actually exists.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

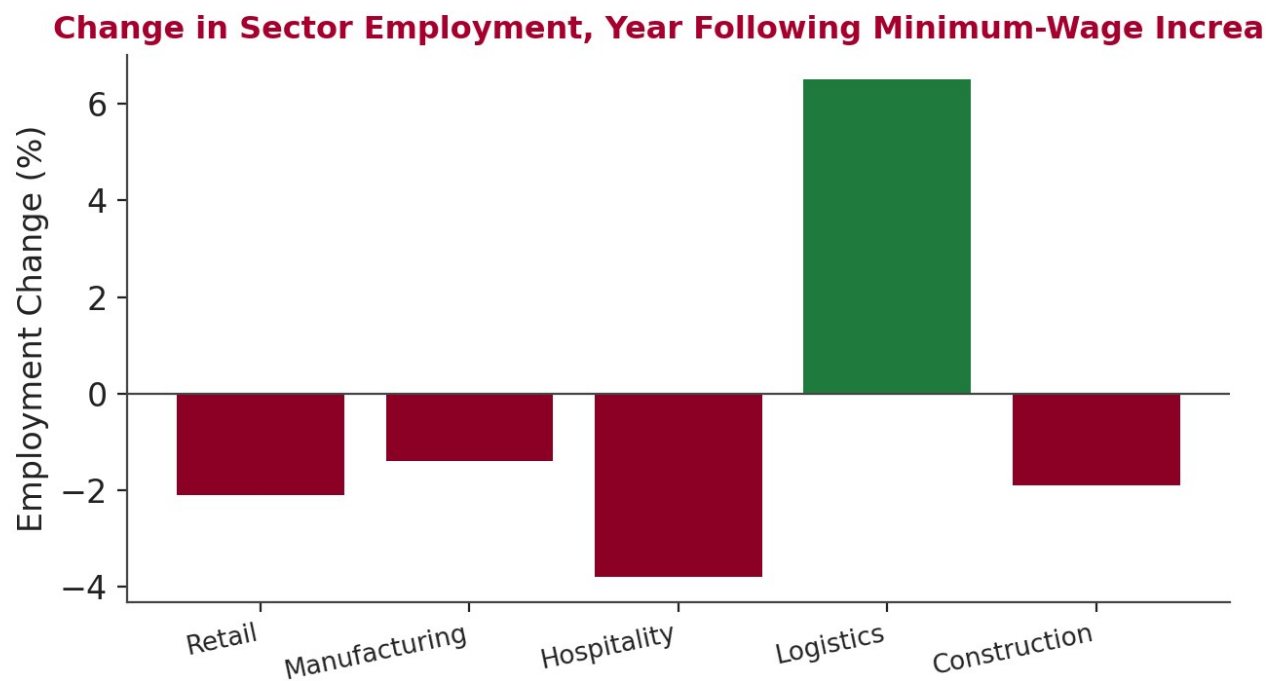
Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Yes, the two measures move in the same direction relative to the prior year in every single year shown.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the 2018 data point, where the two measures move in opposite directions from the year before.
✓ B	No, because 2018 shows a year where the temperature anomaly rose from the year before, but the number of bleaching events fell from the year before.	Choice B is the best answer. correctly identifies the one specific year (2018) where the two measures moved in opposite directions, disproving the “no exceptions” claim.
X C	No, because bleaching events and temperature anomaly were both at their highest in 2021, which the claim does not account for.	Choice C is incorrect — is a true but irrelevant observation — the claim is about year-over-year direction, not about which year had the highest values.
X D	No, because temperature anomaly and bleaching events moved in opposite directions in most years shown, not just a few.	Choice D is incorrect — overstates the disagreement — most years actually do move in the same direction; only one year (2018) breaks the pattern.

Question 7

Hard

An op-ed argued: “The minimum-wage increase clearly hurt employment across the board — every sector's employment fell in the year after the policy took effect.” The bar chart shows the percent change in employment by sector in the year following the minimum-wage increase.



Which choice most directly and completely undermines the op-ed's claim, using only the data shown?

- A. Logistics employment rose by 6.5% over the same period, the only sector shown with a positive change.
- B. Retail employment fell by only 2.1%, a smaller decline than in hospitality.
- C. Construction employment fell by 1.9%, similar to the decline in manufacturing.
- D. Hospitality had the largest employment decline of any sector shown, at 3.8%.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The op-ed's claim is absolute: “every sector's employment fell.”
- The chart shows Logistics with a +6.5% change — a rise, not a fall — which is a direct exception to “every sector.”
- Choices B, C, and D all describe sectors that did decline, which is consistent with (not contrary to) the op-ed's claim, so none of them undermine it.

Tip

To undermine an “every” or “across the board” claim using a chart, scan specifically for the one bar that breaks the pattern — usually the bar with a different sign (positive vs. negative) or an unusually different value from the rest.

Trap

Choices B, C, and D all sound like they could be “counterevidence” because they cite specific numbers from the chart, but reporting a decline in another sector actually confirms the op-ed's pattern rather than contradicting it — only the one positive value matters here.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

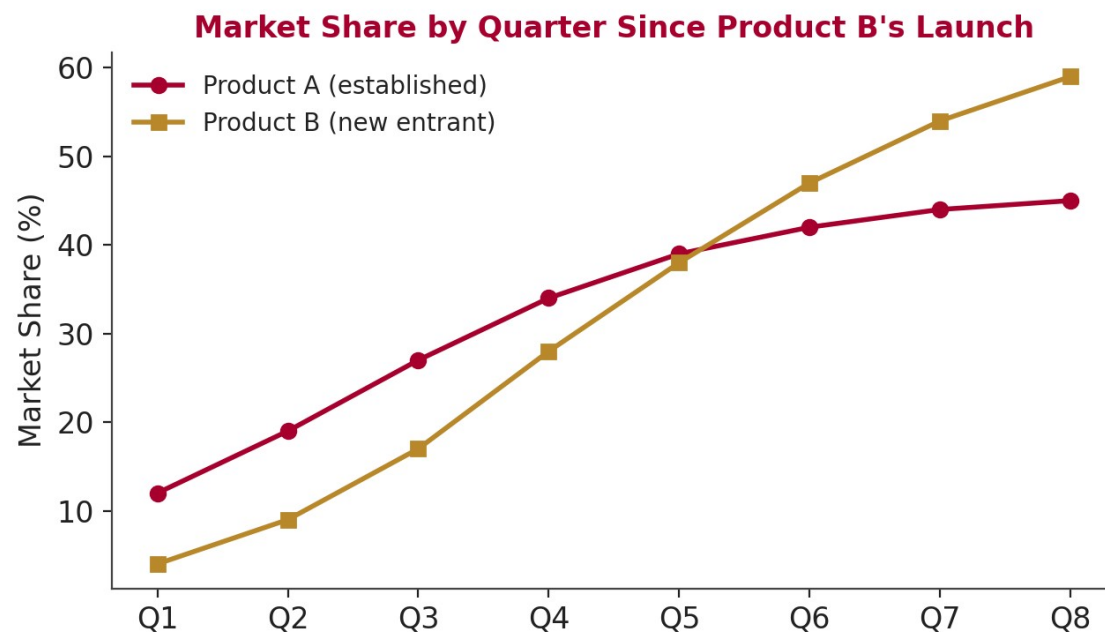
Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Logistics employment rose by 6.5% over the same period, the only sector shown with a positive change.	Choice A is the best answer. is the single sector with a positive employment change, directly contradicting the claim that “every sector's employment fell.”
✗ B	Retail employment fell by only 2.1%, a smaller decline than in hospitality.	Choice B is incorrect — describes another sector's decline, which is consistent with (not contrary to) the op-ed's claim.
✗ C	Construction employment fell by 1.9%, similar to the decline in manufacturing.	Choice C is incorrect — also describes a decline, again consistent with, rather than contradicting, the claim.
✗ D	Hospitality had the largest employment decline of any sector shown, at 3.8%.	Choice D is incorrect — identifies the largest decline, which strengthens rather than undermines the op-ed's overall claim of widespread decline.

Question 8

Hard

A business analyst wrote: “Product B's growth has been so aggressive that it overtook Product A's market share within the first year of competing head-to-head, and has maintained a lead ever since.” The line graph tracks each product's quarterly market share over the eight quarters since Product B's launch (four quarters per year).



Does the graph support the analyst's claim?

- A.** Yes, because Product B's share exceeds Product A's share starting in Q4, within the first year, and remains ahead through Q8.
- B.** Yes, because Product B's share exceeds Product A's share starting in Q6, within the first year, and remains ahead through Q8.
- C.** No, because Product A's market share also increased over the eight quarters shown.
- D.** No — Product B does overtake Product A and remains ahead through Q8, but the crossover occurs at Q6, in the second year of competition, not within the first year as claimed.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- Reading the two lines quarter by quarter: Product A leads through Q5 (39% vs. 38%); at Q6, Product B (47%) overtakes Product A (42%) and stays ahead through Q8 (59% vs. 45%).
- With four quarters per year, “within the first year” means by Q4 — but the actual crossover happens at Q6, which falls in the second year of competition.
- Because the specific timing claim (“within the first year”) is not supported, even though the general claim (B eventually overtakes and stays ahead) is true, the analyst's full claim is not supported.

Tip

When a claim includes a specific timeframe (“within the first year”), convert that phrase into the exact data points it covers (here, quarters 1 through 4) before checking whether the graph actually supports it — don't just check whether the general trend eventually happens.

Trap

Choice B correctly names Q6 as the crossover point but then mislabels Q6 as “within the first year” — with four quarters per year, Q6 is actually the second quarter of year two, a detail easy to miss when scanning quickly.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Yes, because Product B's share exceeds Product A's share starting in Q4, within the first year, and remains ahead through Q8.	Choice A is incorrect — misreads the graph — Product A is still ahead at Q4 (34% vs. 28%); the crossover has not yet happened at that point.
X B	Yes, because Product B's share exceeds Product A's share starting in Q6, within the first year, and remains ahead through Q8.	Choice B is incorrect — correctly identifies Q6 as the crossover point but incorrectly calls Q6 “within the first year” — Q6 is actually in year two.
X C	No, because Product A's market share also increased over the eight quarters shown.	Choice C is incorrect — is true (Product A's share does rise) but doesn't address the specific timing claim about when B overtook A.
✓ D	No — Product B does overtake Product A and remains ahead through Q8, but the crossover occurs at Q6, in the second year of competition, not within the first year as claimed.	Choice D is the best answer. correctly separates the two parts of the claim — confirming the eventual, lasting lead while correctly placing the crossover in year two, not year one.

Quick Review — Command of Evidence: Quantitative

Skill	Frequen cy	Key Move	Main Trap
Command of Evidence: Quantitative	1-2/ module	Describe the trend yourself; check each part of the claim.	A true number that doesn't match the specific claim.

SECTION 6

Command of Evidence: Resolve the Paradox

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Command of Evidence: Resolve the Paradox

A related Command of Evidence format: the passage presents two things that are both true, but that seem to contradict each other. Your job is to find the one new fact — never stated in the passage — that lets both sides stand true at the same time.

What a Paradox Actually Is

- A paradox is not just two sentences that disagree — it rests on an assumption that something we normally expect to hold true should hold here too.
- A rule we believe: a pattern we'd normally expect (more spending should improve results; a safe practice should reduce harm).
- A case that breaks it: a group, place, or moment where the normal pattern doesn't show up.
- Obvious reasons ruled out: the passage removes the easy explanations, so the case feels impossible.
- No explanation given: the passage stops there — finding that missing piece is the task.

Six Types of Paradox

- Statistical — a number moves opposite to what we'd expect.
- Behavior — people act against their own apparent interest.
- Effort — more money, staff, or time goes in, but the result doesn't improve.
- Trend-Break — a steady pattern suddenly changes, with no clear reason.
- Comparison — two similar groups end up with very different results.
- Reporting — the surprise is in how something was counted or defined, not in what actually happened.

How the Question Is Phrased

The exact wording varies, but the task never changes — find the choice that lets both stated facts stand at once:

- “Which choice, if true, would most help explain the results described in the text?”
- “Which choice best explains this apparent discrepancy?”

Six Types of Paradox (cont.)

- “Which choice, if true, would most help resolve the contradiction described above?”
- “Which choice most logically explains why the result occurred despite the expected pattern?”

Five Wrong-Answer Traps

- Makes it worse — strengthens one side of the paradox instead of connecting both sides. The single most common wrong answer.
- Off-topic — true, but doesn't touch either side of the paradox.
- Just repeats it — restates the surprising fact without explaining it.
- Only half-explains it — fixes one side of the paradox but leaves the other side unexplained.
- Gives up — says “there is no explanation,” or argues with a fact the passage already states. Never correct.

Six Types of Paradox (cont.)

Quick-Reference Checklist: (1) Is this a new fact, not already in the passage? (2) Does it bring both sides of the paradox together, not further apart? (3) Does it explain both halves, not just one? (4) Does it accept the passage as true, instead of arguing with it? The choice that passes all four is correct.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Command of Evidence — Resolve the Paradox — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

A city replaced all incandescent streetlights with far more energy-efficient LED fixtures, expecting a large drop in its municipal electricity bill. Engineers confirmed that each LED fixture drew roughly 70% less power than the incandescent bulb it replaced, and no other lighting was added to the network. Even so, the city's total streetlight electricity costs one year later were almost unchanged.

Which choice, if true, would most help resolve the discrepancy described above? (Trend-Break Paradox)

- A.** Residents had previously complained that several streets were too dimly lit at night.
- B.** Because the new fixtures were so much cheaper to run, the city took the opportunity to roughly triple the total number of streetlights installed across the network.
- C.** LED fixtures generally last far longer than incandescent bulbs before needing replacement.
- D.** The city's electricity rates per kilowatt-hour have remained stable for the past decade.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: a 70% cut in power draw per fixture, with no new lighting added, should produce a large drop in total electricity cost.
- The case that breaks it: costs stayed almost unchanged despite the efficient upgrade.
- Choice B supplies the missing fact: the network itself grew roughly threefold, so far more fixtures — each individually cheaper to run — ended up costing about the same in total. Both sides of the paradox now stand together.

Tip

For a Trend-Break Paradox, look for a choice that reveals something else about the situation changed at the same time as the expected improvement — often in scale or scope — that offsets the improvement.

Trap

Choice C is true and sounds like a benefit of the switch, but longer bulb lifespan affects replacement costs, not the electricity bill described in the passage — it never touches the actual discrepancy.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Residents had previously complained that several streets were too dimly lit at night.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — a complaint about dim streets doesn't explain the unchanged total electricity cost.
✓ B	Because the new fixtures were so much cheaper to run, the city took the opportunity to roughly triple the total number of streetlights installed across the network.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — a roughly threefold increase in the number of fixtures explains why total cost didn't fall despite each fixture using far less power.
X C	LED fixtures generally last far longer than incandescent bulbs before needing replacement.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — bulb lifespan affects maintenance cost, not the electricity bill described in the passage.
X D	The city's electricity rates per kilowatt-hour have remained stable for the past decade.	Choice D is incorrect — off-topic — stable per-unit electricity rates don't explain why total cost didn't fall when power draw per fixture dropped sharply.

Question 2

Medium

A company gave every employee a substantial raise, expecting it to boost morale and reduce how often people called in sick. Human resources data confirmed that pay for every position rose by the same percentage, and no other workplace policies changed that year. Even so, the number of sick days taken per employee rose slightly the year after the raise.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this result? (Behavior Paradox)

- A.** The raise was announced at the company's annual all-staff meeting.
- B.** The same year as the raise, the company also removed its previous limit on how many paid sick days employees could carry over, which had previously discouraged people from using sick days they'd already earned.
- C.** The company's revenue grew steadily throughout the year.
- D.** Employees who received larger raises tended to have worked at the company longer.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: higher pay and unchanged policy should improve morale and, if anything, reduce absenteeism.
- The case that breaks it: sick days rose slightly despite the raise, with no other stated policy changes.
- Choice B reveals a second policy change the passage's “no other policies changed” framing didn't rule out here — the sick-day carryover cap was lifted, removing a prior incentive to avoid taking earned sick time, which explains the increase without contradicting the raise's value.

Tip

For a Behavior Paradox, look for a choice that reveals people had a rational, self-interested reason to act the “wrong” way — a removed restriction or new incentive that changed what behavior actually paid off for them.

Trap

Choice D is a true, specific-sounding detail about who got raises, but it doesn't explain why sick-day usage rose across the board — it describes a pattern within the raises themselves, not a cause of increased absenteeism.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The raise was announced at the company's annual all-staff meeting.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — how the raise was announced has no bearing on later sick-day usage.
✓ B	The same year as the raise, the company also removed its previous limit on how many paid sick days employees could carry over, which had previously discouraged people from using sick days they'd already earned.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — removing the carryover limit took away the previous incentive to avoid using earned sick days, explaining the increase.
X C	The company's revenue grew steadily throughout the year.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — revenue growth doesn't explain individual sick-day behavior.
X D	Employees who received larger raises tended to have worked at the company longer.	Choice D is incorrect — half-explains at most — a raise-size pattern by tenure doesn't explain why sick-day usage rose overall.

Question 3

Medium

A nonprofit organization nearly tripled its annual advertising budget to recruit new donors, expecting a proportional rise in total donations. The number of new individual donors did increase substantially that year. Even so, the organization's total donation revenue for the year was only slightly higher than the year before.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this result? (Effort Paradox)

- A.** The new advertising campaign used a mix of social media and direct mail.
- B.** Most of the new donors recruited through the expanded campaign gave substantially smaller average donations than the organization's existing long-term donors.
- C.** The organization's expenses for administrative overhead remained roughly the same as the previous year.
- D.** Charitable giving nationwide increased modestly that year.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: substantially more advertising spending and substantially more new donors should produce a proportionally larger rise in total donation revenue.
- The case that breaks it: total revenue barely moved despite the surge in new donors.
- Choice B explains the gap directly: the new donors gave much smaller average amounts than existing donors, so a large increase in donor count translated into only a small increase in total revenue.

Tip

For an Effort Paradox, look for a choice that explains why more input (spending, staff, donors) didn't translate into proportionally more of the measured output — often because the new additions were smaller or less effective per unit than what was already there.

Trap

Choice D might seem relevant since it's about donations rising nationally, but a modest nationwide increase doesn't explain why this specific organization's own revenue barely grew despite a huge, organization-specific jump in new donors.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The new advertising campaign used a mix of social media and direct mail.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — the advertising channels used don't explain why revenue didn't rise proportionally.
✓ B	Most of the new donors recruited through the expanded campaign gave substantially smaller average donations than the organization's existing long-term donors.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — smaller average donations from the new donors explain why a big jump in donor count produced only a small revenue increase.
X C	The organization's expenses for administrative overhead remained roughly the same as the previous year.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — stable overhead costs don't explain the size of donation revenue.
X D	Charitable giving nationwide increased modestly that year.	Choice D is incorrect — off-topic and too broad — a modest nationwide trend doesn't explain this specific organization's flat revenue despite its own large increase in new donors.

Question 4

Medium

A retailer's data showed that customers who used its mobile app tended to spend, on average, twice as much per visit as customers who did not use the app. Store management concluded that encouraging more customers to download and use the app would directly increase average spending across the customer base, and launched a campaign to boost app adoption.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain why increasing app adoption might not raise average spending as much as management expects, without disputing the original spending comparison? (Comparison Paradox)

- A.** The app included a feature that let customers scan barcodes to compare prices with competitors.
- B.** App users had already been the retailer's most frequent, highest-spending customers before the app was introduced, having downloaded it specifically because they already shopped there often.
- C.** The app was available for both major mobile operating systems.
- D.** The retailer's total number of physical store locations did not change during the period studied.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: since app users spend twice as much, getting more customers onto the app should raise the average spending of newly converted users to match.
- The case that breaks it (or would): the original comparison may not predict what happens for new app adopters going forward.
- Choice B reveals a selection effect — existing app users were already high spenders before adopting the app, meaning the app itself may not be what causes higher spending; new adopters (who are not already high spenders) may not see the same boost.

Tip

For a Comparison Paradox involving two groups, check whether the groups differ in some way other than the factor being tested — if the “high-performing” group was already different before the studied factor was introduced, applying that factor to a new group may not repeat the result.

Trap

Choice A describes a real feature of the app that could plausibly help customers, but it doesn't address why the original spending gap might not extend to future, newly recruited app users — it doesn't touch the actual gap in reasoning.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The app included a feature that let customers scan barcodes to compare prices with competitors.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — a price-comparison feature doesn't explain why new app users might not match existing users' higher spending.
✓ B	App users had already been the retailer's most frequent, highest-spending customers before the app was introduced, having downloaded it specifically because they already shopped there often.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — existing app users were already high spenders before adopting the app, so the app itself may not be the cause, meaning new adopters may not see the same effect.
X C	The app was available for both major mobile operating systems.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — operating system availability has no bearing on spending patterns.
X D	The retailer's total number of physical store locations did not change during the period studied.	Choice D is incorrect — off-topic — the number of store locations doesn't explain the spending comparison between app users and non-users.

Question 5

Hard

A country's national health agency reported that the overall childhood vaccination rate had risen from 78% to 91% over five years, a substantial and well-documented increase confirmed by clinic records nationwide. Despite this rise, the number of parents who told surveyors they were “very confident” in the safety of childhood vaccines fell slightly over the same five years.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this discrepancy? (Statistical Paradox)

- A.** Clinic record-keeping systems were upgraded to be more accurate during the five-year period.
- B.** Vaccination became legally required for public school enrollment partway through the five-year period, causing many parents to vaccinate their children despite continued personal doubts about safety.
- C.** The national health agency increased its public health advertising budget during the same period.
- D.** Confidence in vaccine safety has historically varied somewhat from year to year in survey data.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: a rising vaccination rate should generally track rising (or at least stable) parental confidence in vaccine safety, since more vaccination is often assumed to reflect more trust.
- The case that breaks it: vaccination rose while stated confidence fell, even slightly.
- Choice B separates the two measures: a new legal requirement explains why vaccination rose even among parents whose actual confidence did not increase — the rate reflects compliance with a mandate, not necessarily a change in belief.

Tip

For a Statistical Paradox where two related numbers move in opposite directions, look for a choice that shows the two numbers were actually measuring two different things all along — a legal requirement can raise a compliance rate without changing the underlying attitude survey.

Trap

Choice D might feel like a safe, cautious answer since it acknowledges normal variation, but a vague statement that confidence “varies” explains nothing about this specific five-year pattern — it is a version of “no explanation,” which is never correct.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Clinic record-keeping systems were upgraded to be more accurate during the five-year period.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — more accurate record-keeping doesn't explain a decline in survey-reported confidence.
✓ B	Vaccination became legally required for public school enrollment partway through the five-year period, causing many parents to vaccinate their children despite continued personal doubts about safety.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — a legal requirement explains why vaccination rates rose independent of parents' actual, and slightly declining, confidence in safety.
X C	The national health agency increased its public health advertising budget during the same period.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — increased advertising spending doesn't by itself explain the specific divergence between the two measures.
X D	Confidence in vaccine safety has historically varied somewhat from year to year in survey data.	Choice D is incorrect — gives up — a vague claim about typical variation doesn't explain this specific five-year divergence.

Question 6

Hard

Emergency room records at a regional hospital network showed that the number of reported severe allergic reactions to a common food ingredient rose by nearly 60% over ten years. Researchers confirmed that food manufacturing and ingredient sourcing for that ingredient had not changed in any documented way over that decade, and that the region's population had grown by less than 5% over the same period.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this result? (Reporting Paradox)

- A.** The hospital network adopted new diagnostic criteria partway through the decade that classified a wider range of symptoms as “severe” allergic reactions than the older criteria had.
- B.** The ingredient in question is commonly found in a wide variety of packaged foods.
- C.** Regional food manufacturers began offering a wider variety of products during the decade.
- D.** Severe allergic reactions can sometimes be difficult to distinguish from other medical conditions with similar symptoms.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: with no change in the ingredient itself and only modest population growth, the true underlying rate of severe reactions should have stayed roughly proportional to the small population increase.
- The case that breaks it: reported severe reactions rose by nearly 60%, far outpacing population growth, with the ingredient unchanged.
- Choice A resolves this as a Reporting Paradox: the surprise is in how cases were counted, not in what biologically happened — a broader diagnostic definition partway through the decade would inflate the reported count without any real increase in the underlying rate.

Tip

A Reporting Paradox is solved by a change in how something was measured, defined, or counted — not by a change in the real-world thing being measured. Watch for choices describing new definitions, new criteria, or new detection methods.

Trap

Choice D might feel like it could contribute to some misdiagnosis, but it describes a general, constant difficulty rather than a specific change that happened during the ten-year period — it doesn't explain why the reported rate specifically rose over that decade.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	The hospital network adopted new diagnostic criteria partway through the decade that classified a wider range of symptoms as “severe” allergic reactions than the older criteria had.	Choice A is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — a change in diagnostic criteria partway through the decade would inflate the count of reported “severe” reactions without any real change in the underlying rate.
✗ B	The ingredient in question is commonly found in a wide variety of packaged foods.	Choice B is incorrect — off-topic — how widely an ingredient is used doesn't explain a change in the reported reaction rate over time.
✗ C	Regional food manufacturers began offering a wider variety of products during the decade.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — a wider product variety doesn't, by itself, explain a near-60% rise in severe reaction reports when the ingredient itself is unchanged.
✗ D	Severe allergic reactions can sometimes be difficult to distinguish from other medical conditions with similar symptoms.	Choice D is incorrect — gives up — a general, constant diagnostic difficulty doesn't explain why the reported rate specifically changed over this ten-year period.

Question 7

Hard

A national parks agency doubled the number of rangers patrolling a popular wilderness area, expecting a large drop in the number of hikers who became lost and required rescue. Ranger patrol hours in the area did in fact double as planned, and no other safety measures were added. Even so, the number of lost-hiker rescue operations in the area rose slightly the following year.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this result, without disputing that patrol hours truly doubled? (Effort Paradox)

- A.** The additional rangers received the same training as existing staff.
- B.** Visitor numbers to the wilderness area also rose sharply the same year, following a surge in social media posts describing the area's scenic trails.
- C.** The agency's total budget for the wilderness area increased that year.
- D.** Some of the new rangers were reassigned from a different wilderness area within the same park system.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: doubling ranger patrol hours, with nothing else changing, should reduce the rate of hikers becoming lost and needing rescue.
- The case that breaks it: rescues rose slightly despite the doubled patrols.
- Choice B supplies the missing fact: a sharp, independent rise in total visitor numbers means far more people were hiking the trails — even with double the rangers, the much larger pool of hikers could still produce more total lost-hiker incidents.

Tip

For an Effort Paradox, check whether the scale of the underlying activity (here, total visitors) also grew at the same time as the effort being increased — a bigger “pool” of opportunities for the problem to occur can outweigh a real improvement in effort.

Trap

Choice D might seem like it could weaken the patrol increase's effectiveness (since some rangers were reassigned rather than newly hired), but the passage already confirms total patrol hours in this area doubled as planned — where the rangers previously worked doesn't undercut that stated fact.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The additional rangers received the same training as existing staff.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — equal training doesn't explain why rescues still rose despite doubled patrol hours.
✓ B	Visitor numbers to the wilderness area also rose sharply the same year, following a surge in social media posts describing the area's scenic trails.	Choice B is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — a sharp rise in total visitors means many more hikers were on the trails, which can increase total rescues even with doubled patrols.
X C	The agency's total budget for the wilderness area increased that year.	Choice C is incorrect — off-topic — a budget increase doesn't itself explain the rescue trend.
X D	Some of the new rangers were reassigned from a different wilderness area within the same park system.	Choice D is incorrect — doesn't dispute the stated fact that total patrol hours in this area doubled, so it doesn't explain the outcome.

Question 8

Hard

A university implemented a mandatory financial-literacy course for all incoming first-year students, expecting it to reduce the rate of students who took on high-interest credit-card debt during college. Course completion records confirmed that every incoming student completed the course as required, and no other financial-aid or orientation policies changed that year. Even so, the percentage of students carrying high-interest credit-card debt by the end of their first year was almost identical to the percentage in the year before the course was introduced.

Which choice, if true, would most help explain this result? (Trend-Break Paradox)

- A.** The course was taught by a mix of faculty and outside financial professionals.
- B.** A survey administered right after the course found that most students rated the material as “informative.”
- C.** The same year the course launched, several credit-card companies increased their marketing efforts specifically targeting first-year students on campus, offering sign-up incentives such as free merchandise.
- D.** The university's tuition costs rose slightly that year compared to the year before.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The rule we expect: universal completion of a financial-literacy course, with nothing else changing, should reduce risky credit-card borrowing among first-year students.
- The case that breaks it: the debt rate stayed almost identical despite full course completion.
- Choice C reveals a second, simultaneous change the passage's “no other policies changed” framing didn't rule out: a fresh, targeted marketing push by credit-card companies, which could offset any behavioral change the course produced.

Tip

As with several paradox types, check carefully what kind of “no other changes” a passage actually claims — here it rules out financial-aid and orientation policy changes specifically, leaving outside forces (like private company marketing) completely unaddressed.

Trap

Choice B might feel like it supports the course's value (students found it informative), but positive feedback about how a course was received is not evidence about its actual effect on financial behavior — it never touches the paradox itself.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The course was taught by a mix of faculty and outside financial professionals.	Choice A is incorrect — off-topic — who taught the course doesn't explain why the debt rate stayed unchanged.
X B	A survey administered right after the course found that most students rated the material as “informative.”	Choice B is incorrect — off-topic — positive course ratings don't explain actual borrowing behavior, and don't resolve the paradox.
✓ C	The same year the course launched, several credit-card companies increased their marketing efforts specifically targeting first-year students on campus, offering sign-up incentives such as free merchandise.	Choice C is the best answer. supplies the missing fact — a simultaneous, targeted marketing push by credit-card companies could offset any reduction in risky borrowing the course might otherwise have produced.
X D	The university's tuition costs rose slightly that year compared to the year before.	Choice D is incorrect — off-topic — a modest tuition increase doesn't specifically explain the unchanged credit-card debt rate among first-year students.

Quick Review — Command of Evidence: Resolve the Paradox

Skill	Frequency	Key Move	Main Trap
Resolve the Paradox	Within Command of Evidence	Find the new fact that lets both sides stand true.	A choice that strengthens one side instead of connecting both.

SECTION 7

Inferences

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Inferences

0–3 questions in Module 1 • 0–2 in Module 2 • the question asks what the passage implies but never states outright. Answer choices are complete sentences — never single words.

How to Think: The Inference Chain

Every inference question follows the same chain:

- THE PROMPT — what the question is actually asking you to conclude.
- PREMISES (FACTS) — everything stated directly in the passage. Nothing else exists for the purposes of this question.
- NO CONCLUSION, NO NEW INFO — the correct answer adds nothing beyond the stated facts; it only combines or narrows them into a single necessary conclusion.

Theory

- An inference must be true based on what the text says — not what you think, not outside knowledge, not what might be true.
- The “one small step” rule: textual fact + one logical step = correct inference. More than one step = too far.

Inferences (cont.)

- Must be true, not could be true. A correct inference is unavoidable from the text, not merely plausible.
- Avoid extreme language — “always,” “never,” “entirely,” “the only” are almost always wrong.
- When a passage rules out one explanation directly, the inference usually points to whatever explanation is left standing.

Transition words are clues: "however," "therefore," "consequently," "in contrast" signal logical relationships.

- You should always be able to point to a specific line that supports the inference.

Six-question test for each answer choice:

- Does the passage require this to be true?
- Can I point to a specific line that directly supports it?
- Is this going beyond what the author actually said?
- Does it use extreme language?

Inferences (cont.)

- Is this just my outside knowledge or assumption?
- Does it match the one-small-step rule?

Step-by-Step Approach

Read the question and identify the specific lines it refers to.

Restate the idea in those lines in your own words.

Before looking at choices, complete: "Based on this, I can conclude that ____."

Eliminate choices that use extreme language, go too far, or rely on outside knowledge.

For remaining choices, ask: "Is this unavoidable based on the text, or just possible?"

Choose the clearest "one small step" from the text — cautious and grounded.

“Most Logically Completes the Text” — A Key Subtype

- This is an inference subtype where the blank sits at the end of the passage.
- The completion must be forced by the prior sentences — not just a sentence that fits the general topic.
- Everything before the blank is a set of premises leading to one necessary conclusion.
- Watch for a pivot word right before the blank — therefore, thus, however, in fact — it signals what kind of conclusion is required.
- If a fact is stated twice from two angles (a result, and a possible cause the passage rules out), the blank usually resolves that exact tension.

Four Wrong-Answer Traps

- Too strong — absolute language (all, never, only, every) that the passage does not support.
- Out of scope — brings in a factor, judgment, or recommendation the passage never mentions.
- Reversed logic — flips a stated relationship (treats “A caused B” as “B caused A”).

“Most Logically Completes the Text” — A Key Subtype (cont.)

- Plausible but unproven — sounds reasonable, but the passage never actually guarantees it.

Quick Test: The best inference is the one you could defend using only quotes and facts from the passage — no extra reasoning, no outside knowledge, no benefit of the doubt. If you have to add anything to make it true, it's wrong.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Inferences — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

A study tracked commuting patterns in a mid-sized city after a new light-rail line opened connecting the suburbs to downtown. Ridership on the light-rail line grew steadily for two years. Researchers found that traffic congestion on the parallel highway, measured by average rush-hour speed, did not improve over the same period — average speeds remained essentially unchanged. Further investigation showed that most light-rail riders had previously commuted by bus, not by car, and that the number of cars entering downtown during rush hour also remained roughly constant.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** the light-rail line failed to attract enough riders to justify its construction cost.
- B.** the light-rail line primarily drew riders away from existing bus service rather than reducing car traffic.
- C.** traffic congestion in the city will continue to worsen regardless of future transit investment.
- D.** bus service in the city should be eliminated now that the light-rail line is operational.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: ridership grew steadily; highway speeds stayed unchanged; most riders switched from bus, not car; car volume stayed constant.
- No new information or conclusion beyond these stated facts is needed — the passage already states directly that most riders came from bus service, and that car volume was unaffected.
- The correct answer is a direct restatement of two combined premises (riders came from bus, cars stayed the same) as a single logical conclusion.

Tip

When a passage gives you a surprising result (steady ridership growth, but no change in traffic) and then explains it with a specific stated fact (riders came from buses, not cars), the correct inference usually just restates that explanation as the conclusion.

Trap

Choice A sounds like a reasonable real-world judgment about the rail line's value, but nothing in the passage discusses cost or whether the project was “worth it” — that judgment requires information the passage never provides.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	the light-rail line failed to attract enough riders to justify its construction cost.	Choice A is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage never discusses construction costs or whether the investment was justified.
✓ B	the light-rail line primarily drew riders away from existing bus service rather than reducing car traffic.	Choice B is the best answer. is forced directly by the stated facts: riders switched from bus (not car), and car volume was unchanged — exactly explaining the unchanged highway speeds.
X C	traffic congestion in the city will continue to worsen regardless of future transit investment.	Choice C is incorrect — is too strong — the passage describes one transit line's effect, not a permanent, unchangeable rule about all future investment.
X D	bus service in the city should be eliminated now that the light-rail line is operational.	Choice D is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage never suggests eliminating bus service, and doing so is a policy recommendation, not a conclusion from data.

Question 2

Medium

A food-safety agency inspected two types of restaurants — those that had voluntarily adopted a digital temperature-logging system for refrigerated storage, and those that still used manual paper logs. Restaurants using the digital system had violation rates for improper food storage temperature that were less than half those of restaurants using paper logs. However, restaurants that adopted the digital system were disproportionately larger chains with dedicated kitchen-safety staff, while paper-log restaurants were more often small, independently owned establishments.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** digital temperature logging directly causes restaurants to have fewer food storage violations.
- B.** the lower violation rate among digital-system restaurants may be explained by factors other than the logging method itself, such as staffing differences between the two groups.
- C.** small, independently owned restaurants are incapable of maintaining safe food storage temperatures.
- D.** all restaurants should be legally required to adopt digital temperature-logging systems.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: digital-system restaurants had less than half the violation rate of paper-log restaurants; digital-system restaurants were disproportionately larger chains with dedicated safety staff; paper-log restaurants were more often small and independent.
- The passage does not say the digital system itself caused fewer violations — it separately notes a second difference (staffing, chain size) between the two groups being compared.
- The correct inference must stay cautious: it cannot assert direct causation the passage doesn't establish, only that an alternative explanation is plausible given the stated facts.

Tip

When a passage describes two groups differing in the outcome being measured AND in some other characteristic, the correct inference is almost always a cautious one that acknowledges the second characteristic as a possible explanation — not a confident causal claim.

Trap

Choice A looks like the obvious takeaway from the headline statistic (lower violations for the digital group), but the passage itself supplies a reason to doubt a simple causal reading — a “must be true” inference cannot ignore information the passage itself provides.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	digital temperature logging directly causes restaurants to have fewer food storage violations.	Choice A is incorrect — is too strong — the passage explicitly notes a confounding difference (staffing, chain size) that the passage itself flags as a competing explanation.
✓ B	the lower violation rate among digital-system restaurants may be explained by factors other than the logging method itself, such as staffing differences between the two groups.	Choice B is the best answer. is the cautious, forced conclusion — the passage's own mention of staffing and chain-size differences directly supports this alternative-explanation reading.
X C	small, independently owned restaurants are incapable of maintaining safe food storage temperatures.	Choice C is incorrect — is too strong and reversed — the passage describes a correlation with staffing resources, not a claim about independent restaurants being “incapable.”
X D	all restaurants should be legally required to adopt digital temperature-logging systems.	Choice D is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage reports a finding, not a policy recommendation.

Question 3

Medium

Anthropologists studying a coastal community noticed that despite ready access to abundant local fish stocks, most households consumed imported, processed meat as their primary protein source. Interviews revealed that fishing had historically been performed by a specific clan, and that eating fish caught by other clans was considered a violation of longstanding social custom for households outside that clan. Notably, the few households descended from the original fishing clan continued to eat locally caught fish regularly.

Based on this passage, it is most reasonable to conclude that _____

- A.** imported meat is nutritionally superior to locally caught fish.
- B.** social custom, rather than availability or nutritional preference, most plausibly accounts for most households' reliance on imported meat.
- C.** the fishing clan intentionally restricted the local fish supply to raise its value.
- D.** all coastal communities avoid eating locally available fish for similar reasons.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: fish is locally abundant; most households eat imported meat instead; eating fish from other clans violates social custom for non-fishing-clan households; fishing-clan descendants still eat local fish.
- The passage rules out availability (fish is abundant) as the explanation, and the custom detail directly explains why only fishing-clan households continue eating fish.
- This is a “one small step” inference: two premises (custom applies only outside the clan; only the clan still eats fish) combine into one necessary conclusion about the cause of the broader pattern.

Tip

When a passage rules out the “obvious” explanation (here, availability) and then supplies a specific alternative (social custom) that also explains an exception within the data (the fishing clan still eating fish), the correct inference usually names that specific alternative as the cause.

Trap

Choice C might feel plausible as an economic explanation, but nothing in the passage discusses supply restriction or pricing motives — this introduces a factor entirely outside the passage's scope.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	imported meat is nutritionally superior to locally caught fish.	Choice A is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage never compares nutritional value between imported meat and local fish.
✓ B	social custom, rather than availability or nutritional preference, most plausibly accounts for most households' reliance on imported meat.	Choice B is the best answer. is forced by the stated facts — availability is ruled out, and the custom explanation directly accounts for both the general pattern and the fishing-clan exception.
X C	the fishing clan intentionally restricted the local fish supply to raise its value.	Choice C is incorrect — is out of scope — no information about intentional supply restriction or economic motive appears in the passage.
X D	all coastal communities avoid eating locally available fish for similar reasons.	Choice D is incorrect — is too strong — the passage describes one specific community's custom, not a universal rule about “all coastal communities.”

Question 4

Medium

A logistics company switched half of its delivery fleet to electric vans, keeping the other half as diesel vans, and tracked on-time delivery rates for one year. Electric vans had a slightly higher on-time delivery rate than diesel vans in warm-weather months, but a noticeably lower on-time rate during the coldest winter months, when battery range and charging speed both decrease in low temperatures. Route assignments were made randomly between the two van types throughout the year.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** electric vans are less reliable than diesel vans overall, regardless of season.
- B.** the relative on-time performance of electric vans compared to diesel vans appears to depend in part on seasonal temperature.
- C.** the company should discontinue its electric van program entirely.
- D.** diesel vans will always outperform electric vans during winter months in any climate.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: electric vans outperformed diesel vans in warm months but underperformed in the coldest winter months; route assignment was random (ruling out route difficulty as an explanation); cold weather is stated to reduce battery range and charging speed.
- The passage supplies the exact mechanism (temperature effects on batteries) that explains the seasonal reversal — the conclusion should track this pattern precisely, not overgeneralize in either direction.
- Because performance differs by season within the very same data set, a “must be true” inference can only claim that season plays a role — not that one van type is unconditionally better.

Tip

When a passage shows a pattern reversing under one specific condition (here, cold weather), the safest and most defensible inference states that the outcome depends on that condition — resist the pull toward a single, one-size-fits-all conclusion.

Trap

Choice A takes the (real) winter underperformance and generalizes it into an “overall” judgment, ignoring the passage's own report that electric vans actually did slightly better in warm months — a classic too-strong error that clips off half the data.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	electric vans are less reliable than diesel vans overall, regardless of season.	Choice A is incorrect — is too strong and contradicted in part — the passage states electric vans performed slightly better in warm-weather months.
✓ B	the relative on-time performance of electric vans compared to diesel vans appears to depend in part on seasonal temperature.	Choice B is the best answer. is precisely forced by the passage's own seasonal breakdown and its explanation involving battery range and charging speed in cold weather.
X C	the company should discontinue its electric van program entirely.	Choice C is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage reports a data pattern, not a recommendation to end the program.
X D	diesel vans will always outperform electric vans during winter months in any climate.	Choice D is incorrect — is too strong — the passage describes this specific company's data in this specific climate, not a universal claim about “any climate.”

Question 5

Hard

A regional government offered a tax credit to companies that hired workers who had been unemployed for over a year. Two years after the program began, the long-term unemployment rate in the region had fallen by 18%. Program administrators noted, however, that a nearly identical decline in long-term unemployment occurred over the same period in a neighboring region that offered no such tax credit, and that both regions experienced a broader economic expansion during those two years that increased hiring across nearly every industry.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** the tax credit program had no effect whatsoever on long-term unemployment in the region.
- B.** the region's overall economic expansion, rather than the tax credit specifically, may account for a substantial share of the decline in long-term unemployment.
- C.** the neighboring region should have also offered a similar tax credit.
- D.** tax credits are an ineffective policy tool in every economic context.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: long-term unemployment fell 18% in the region with the tax credit; a nearly identical decline occurred in a neighboring region without the credit; both regions saw broad economic expansion and increased hiring during the same period.
- The comparison with the neighboring region is the key move: whatever caused the decline there (economic expansion) could just as easily be driving most of the decline in the region with the tax credit.
- The conclusion must stay measured — “may account for a substantial share” — since the passage doesn't rule out the tax credit having some smaller effect, only that it cannot be the sole or primary explanation.

Tip

Whenever a passage compares a region or group with an intervention to a similar one without it, and both show the same result, the correct inference points to whatever both groups had in common as the more likely cause — not the one factor that differed.

Trap

Choice A overreaches into “no effect whatsoever,” a claim stronger than the evidence supports — the passage shows the economic expansion likely explains most of the decline, but it never rules out the tax credit contributing at all, so “no effect whatsoever” goes further than the facts allow.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	the tax credit program had no effect whatsoever on long-term unemployment in the region.	Choice A is incorrect — is too strong — the passage shows economic expansion likely explains much of the decline but never proves the tax credit had literally zero effect.
✓ B	the region's overall economic expansion, rather than the tax credit specifically, may account for a substantial share of the decline in long-term unemployment.	Choice B is the best answer. is the cautious, forced conclusion — the shared factor (economic expansion) across both regions is the most likely explanation for the shared outcome.
X C	the neighboring region should have also offered a similar tax credit.	Choice C is incorrect — is out of scope — this is a policy recommendation, not a conclusion drawn from the stated data.
X D	tax credits are an ineffective policy tool in every economic context.	Choice D is incorrect — is too strong — one comparison in one region says nothing about tax credits “in every economic context.”

Question 6

Hard

Ecologists compared two populations of the same freshwater fish species living in separate lakes. In Lake A, where a competing fish species was introduced twenty years ago, the native fish had grown, on average, 15% larger in body size than native fish in Lake B, which had no competing species introduced. Further study found that in Lake A, the native fish had also shifted to feeding primarily at greater depths than the competing species preferred, while in Lake B, native fish continued feeding at the same shallow depths as their ancestors.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** the competing species in Lake A directly caused the native fish to grow larger through increased competition for food.
- B.** the native fish in Lake A most plausibly grew larger in part because their shift to deeper feeding grounds gave them access to a different, and possibly richer, food source than the shallow waters used in Lake B.
- C.** native fish populations in Lake B will eventually become extinct due to their smaller body size.
- D.** the competing species introduced in Lake A will eventually be eliminated by the native fish population.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: Lake A's native fish are 15% larger and shifted to deeper feeding grounds after a competing species was introduced; Lake B's native fish stayed at shallow depths and are smaller.
- The passage does not state that competition directly caused larger size — it states a behavioral shift (depth of feeding) that plausibly explains the size difference, without confirming the exact mechanism.
- This is a two-step, “one small step” inference: competition → behavioral shift (stated) → plausible size difference (the necessary next step, but stated cautiously, not as certain fact).

Tip

Be careful when a passage describes a cause (competition), an intermediate behavior (a shift in feeding depth), and an outcome (larger size) — the correct inference should connect the behavior to the outcome precisely as the passage frames it, not skip straight from the original cause to the outcome as though it were direct and certain.

Trap

Choice A skips over the passage's own intermediate explanation (the shift to deeper feeding) and asserts a direct causal link from competition to size that the passage never explicitly draws — it collapses two separate stated facts into an oversimplified, overconfident claim.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	the competing species in Lake A directly caused the native fish to grow larger through increased competition for food.	Choice A is incorrect — is too strong — the passage links competition to a behavioral shift, not directly and explicitly to size, skipping a step the passage itself includes.
✓ B	the native fish in Lake A most plausibly grew larger in part because their shift to deeper feeding grounds gave them access to a different, and possibly richer, food source than the shallow waters used in Lake B.	Choice B is the best answer. correctly connects the stated behavioral shift (deeper feeding) to the plausible explanation for the size difference, without overstating certainty.
X C	native fish populations in Lake B will eventually become extinct due to their smaller body size.	Choice C is incorrect — is too strong and out of scope — nothing in the passage discusses extinction risk for either population.
X D	the competing species introduced in Lake A will eventually be eliminated by the native fish population.	Choice D is incorrect — is out of scope — the passage says nothing about the competing species being eliminated.

Question 7

Hard

A publisher analyzed sales data for its two imprints. Imprint X, which primarily releases hardcover books, saw average per-title sales decline by 12% over five years. Imprint Y, which shifted the majority of its catalog to paperback and digital formats over the same period, saw average per-title sales rise by 9%. However, industry-wide data show that overall book sales across all formats and publishers grew modestly over the same five-year period, and Imprint Y's titles, on average, covered more commercially popular genres than Imprint X's titles.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** switching from hardcover to paperback and digital formats is the primary reason for Imprint Y's sales increase.
- B.** given the differences in genre and the broader industry-wide growth, it cannot be determined from this information alone whether the format shift specifically drove Imprint Y's improved sales.
- C.** Imprint X should immediately discontinue all hardcover publishing.
- D.** hardcover books are no longer a viable format for any publisher.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: Imprint X (hardcover) sales fell 12%; Imprint Y (shifted to paperback/digital) sales rose 9%; industry-wide sales grew modestly overall; Imprint Y's titles skewed toward more commercially popular genres than Imprint X's.
- Two separate confounding factors are stated directly: overall industry growth (which could lift Y regardless of format) and a genre difference between the two imprints (which could explain sales differences on its own).
- With two distinct, stated alternative explanations and no way to isolate the format's specific effect, the only conclusion the evidence actually forces is that the cause cannot be determined from the passage alone.

Tip

When a passage stacks up more than one plausible alternative explanation (here: industry-wide growth and genre differences) without any way to isolate them, the correct inference is often a cautious statement that the cause cannot be determined — not a specific pick between the alternatives.

Trap

Choice A takes the intuitive, headline-friendly explanation (the format shift worked) and asserts it as fact, but the passage provides two separate reasons to doubt that a clean causal story — genre mix and industry-wide growth — can be ruled out.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	switching from hardcover to paperback and digital formats is the primary reason for Imprint Y's sales increase.	Choice A is incorrect — is too strong — the passage supplies at least two alternative explanations (genre mix, industry growth) that the passage never rules out.
✓ B	given the differences in genre and the broader industry-wide growth, it cannot be determined from this information alone whether the format shift specifically drove Imprint Y's improved sales.	Choice B is the best answer. is the accurate, forced conclusion given that multiple stated factors make the format's specific effect impossible to isolate from this information alone.
X C	Imprint X should immediately discontinue all hardcover publishing.	Choice C is incorrect — is out of scope — this is a business recommendation, not a conclusion drawn from the data.
X D	hardcover books are no longer a viable format for any publisher.	Choice D is incorrect — is too strong — the passage describes one publisher's two imprints, not the viability of hardcover books industry-wide.

Question 8

Hard

Public health officials tracked vaccination rates and disease incidence in a region over a decade. As vaccination rates for a particular childhood illness rose from 60% to 95% of the eligible population, reported cases of the illness fell by more than 90%. In the final two years of the study, however, a small but real increase in reported cases occurred even as vaccination rates remained steady at 95%. Investigators found that nearly all of the new cases in those final two years occurred among unvaccinated infants too young to receive the vaccine, whose only contact with the illness could be traced to unvaccinated older siblings or classmates.

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A.** the vaccine had become less effective by the final two years of the study.
- B.** the small increase in cases during the final two years most plausibly resulted from transmission among the unvaccinated minority rather than from a decline in the vaccine's effectiveness.
- C.** vaccination should be mandated for all members of the population without exception.
- D.** the illness will inevitably return to its original incidence rate regardless of vaccination efforts.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- Premises: vaccination rates rose to 95% and then held steady; cases fell over 90% overall; in the final two years, a small case increase occurred entirely among unvaccinated infants, traced to unvaccinated siblings or classmates.
- The passage explicitly traces the new cases to the unvaccinated minority, not to vaccinated individuals — which rules out declining vaccine effectiveness as the explanation for this specific increase.
- This is a “ruled out by elimination” inference: the passage removes the most obvious alternative explanation (vaccine failure) by tracing every new case to a different, specific source (unvaccinated contacts).

Tip

When a passage explains an unexpected uptick by tracing it to a specific, named source (here, unvaccinated contacts), that traced explanation is almost always the correct inference — it directly rules out the more dramatic-sounding alternative (vaccine failure) that the passage doesn't support.

Trap

Choice A is the more dramatic, headline-style explanation for a case increase, and it might feel like the “obvious” interpretation of “cases rose” on its own — but the passage specifically traces the new cases to unvaccinated individuals, directly contradicting a vaccine-effectiveness explanation.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	the vaccine had become less effective by the final two years of the study.	Choice A is incorrect — is contradicted by the passage, which traces the new cases specifically to unvaccinated infants and their unvaccinated contacts, not to vaccinated individuals.
✓ B	the small increase in cases during the final two years most plausibly resulted from transmission among the unvaccinated minority rather than from a decline in the vaccine's effectiveness.	Choice B is the best answer. is forced directly by the passage's own tracing of the new cases to the unvaccinated minority.
X C	vaccination should be mandated for all members of the population without exception.	Choice C is incorrect — is out of scope — this is a policy recommendation, not a conclusion drawn from the study's data.
X D	the illness will inevitably return to its original incidence rate regardless of vaccination efforts.	Choice D is incorrect — is too strong — the passage describes a small, traceable increase, not an inevitable full return to the original incidence rate.

Quick Review — Inferences

Skill	Frequency	Key Move	Main Trap
Inferences	0-3/ module	One small step only — “must be true,” not “could be true.”	Extreme language or outside knowledge.

Golden Rules

- Read the question first — always.
- Predict your own answer before looking at the choices.
- Every word in an answer choice counts — one wrong word makes the whole answer wrong.
- The correct answer almost always rephrases the passage — same idea, different words, no new information.
- In argument questions, separate premises (never attacked) from the assumption (always the real target).
- There are no trick questions. If you reason carefully from the text, the right answer will be clearly the best fit.

Well done.

Information and Ideas: theory and worked questions complete.